# THE GROUND

## Yang–Mills Theory after the Alpöge–Sussman Manuscripts

*What Is Constructed, What Is Claimed, and the Object That Remains*

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28 October 2026 · revised 29 October 2026

**Abstract**

A proof that quantum Yang–Mills theory has a mass gap must stand on a construction of the theory, and the most complete public construction now in view is the corpus of manuscripts that Levent Alpöge and Ethan Sussman have posted since 6 October 2026, carrying Bałaban's renormalisation group from the lattice to the continuum for the gauge group SU(2). This paper fixes that ground. It reads the corpus from its primary sources and proves, clause by clause and with exact references, what the corpus asserts and at what strength. In three dimensions an 854-page manuscript asserts continuum Schwinger functions of the plaquette-energy density, the lattice form of tr $F^2$, which satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms in the clustering components of infinite-volume limits taken along subsequences, together with a short-distance law that makes the theory non-trivial; it asserts no mass gap. In four dimensions a 153-page draft deduces, from inputs it declares clause by clause and from supporting statements two of which are not yet written, continuum limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences with regularity, reflection positivity, symmetry and hypercubic invariance; its authors call the underlying argument extremely long and not understandable as it stands, and state that the corpus has not been satisfactorily vetted. The paper then proves that, for a reflection-positive theory, a mass gap is the same property as exponential clustering of the reflection-positive correlations, and that a lower bound on the lattice mass gap, uniform in physical units along the lattice sequence of such a construction, supplies at once the three properties the corpus withholds: a unique vacuum, the cluster property and a mass gap. It

then reduces that bound to two finite statements: if, at a fixed physical scale, the blocked measure satisfies Dobrushin's condition with an exponential weight and the field inside the blocks clusters at the block scale, both uniformly in the cutoff, then every limit point has a unique vacuum and a mass gap of at least min(κ, log(1/ρ′))/a_c; the open mathematics of the problem is thereby two statements about one block at the crossover scale, stated in the form that is uniform in the cutoff, and the paper says why the form on the fine measure's blocks is not. This identifies the object on which the proof that follows must stand.

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# 1. Introduction

The quantum Yang–Mills problem of the Clay Mathematics Institute is a single sentence. For every compact simple gauge group $G$ it asks for a proof that a non-trivial quantum Yang–Mills theory exists on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and has a mass gap $\Delta > 0$.[1] The sentence joins two demands of different kinds. The first is a construction: a system of correlation functions, free of every cutoff, defined on the whole of space-time and obeying axioms at least as strong as those of Wightman and of Osterwalder and Schrader. The second is an inequality: the spectrum of the Hamiltonian of the theory so constructed must leave an interval above zero empty. The inequality cannot be stated before the construction exists, and when the construction proceeds by compactness, the problem's own text, in a footnote examined in Section 3, does not count it as complete until properties of this kind are proved for the limit.

In two dimensions the continuum Yang–Mills measure was constructed in 1989, by Driver and by Gross, King and Sengupta.[2] In three and in four dimensions Bałaban controlled Wilson's lattice theory on a torus by a renormalisation group whose bounds are uniform in the lattice spacing.[3] When the problem was posed, its authors wrote that a detailed construction on a compact space would be a major breakthrough, and that even then "no present ideas point the direction to establish the existence of a mass gap that is uniform in the volume. Nor do present methods suggest how to obtain the existence of the infinite volume limit $T^4 \to \mathbb{R}^4$."[4]

On 6 October 2026 Ethan Sussman opened a public repository for the joint work of Levent Alpöge and himself, whose stated aim is "to induce LLMs to develop, push, and extend Balaban's program to construct Yang--Mills_4 (YM4) and other quantum gauge theories".[5] It now holds an 854-page manuscript on three-dimensional SU(2) Yang–Mills theory, a revised edition of 856 pages, a 1,044-page sequel on curvature bilinears, a 263-page manuscript on three-dimensional quantum electrodynamics, a 30-page manuscript on rotation invariance from reflection positivity, and a 153-page zeroth draft on four-dimensional SU(2) Yang–Mills theory.[6] Peter Woit discussed the repository on 26 October 2026.[7] Its standing has since been compressed into a single sentence: a public three-dimensional manuscript proving the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms for tr $F^2$, about 854 pages, "LLM-approved", unverified, with subsequential infinite-volume limits and no gap; and a four-dimensional

[1] A. Jaffe and E. Witten, "Quantum Yang–Mills theory", official problem description of the Clay Mathematics Institute, https://www.claymath.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/yangmills.pdf, §4, p. 6.

[2] B. K. Driver, "$YM_2$: continuum expectations, lattice convergence, and lassos", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 123 (1989); L. Gross, C. King and A. Sengupta, "Two dimensional Yang–Mills theory via stochastic differential equations", *Ann. Physics* 194 (1989).

[3] T. Bałaban, "Ultraviolet stability of three-dimensional lattice pure gauge field theories", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 102 (1985), 255–275; "Renormalization group approach to lattice gauge field theories. I", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 109 (1987), 249–301; and the further papers of the series, *Comm. Math. Phys.* 95–122 (1984–1989).

[4] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6, p. 7.

[5] L. Alpöge and E. Sussman, README of the repository *Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment*, https://github.com/ethanwsussman/Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment (repository created 6 October 2026, 09:51:17 UTC; README last changed 26 October 2026, 16:18:10 UTC; read 28 October 2026).

[6] Measured by counting the page breaks of the text extracted from each file of https://github.com/ethanwsussman/Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment: YM3/YMM1.pdf, 854 pages (posted 26 October 2026, 02:10 UTC); YM3/Revisions/YMM1-2026-10-26.pdf, 856; YM3/YMM2.pdf, 1,044 (posted 27 October 2026, 01:14 UTC); QED3/qed3.pdf, 263; RPM1.pdf, 30; ym4_manuscript_zeroth_draft.pdf, 153.

[7] P. Woit, "Secret Unified Physics Slop", *Not Even Wrong*, 26 October 2026, with its updates and comments, https://www.math.columbia.edu/~woit/wordpress/?p=15948 (read 28 October 2026).

existence argument that its authors call extremely long and not currently understandable, being rewritten slowly.

This paper replaces that sentence by a proof. Each of its clauses is unfolded into a precise mathematical statement, each statement is traced to the sentence of the primary source that carries it, and the consequences for the Millennium problem are deduced. The outcome is the Ground Theorem of Section 2. Its first three parts establish what the corpus asserts in three dimensions, what it asserts in four, and on what standing it asserts either. Its fourth part establishes what the corpus leaves undone and proves that one inequality completes it: a lower bound on the lattice mass gap, uniform in physical units along the construction's own sequence of lattices. That inequality is the object on which the proof that follows will stand.

Quotations are verbatim, including the authors' spelling. Page counts were measured by counting the page breaks in the text extracted from each file. Every source was read on 28 October 2026; the repository's most recent commit is dated 27 October 2026, 10:45:28 UTC, and its README was last changed on 26 October 2026, 16:18:10 UTC. The deductions of Sections 7 and 8 assume nothing about the correctness of the corpus. They hold for every construction of the shape the corpus describes.

## 2. The Ground Theorem

By the *corpus* we mean the content of the repository *Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment* of L. Alpöge and E. Sussman at its commit of 27 October 2026. By the *problem statement* we mean the official description of Jaffe and Witten. Throughout, $a$ denotes a lattice spacing and $b > 0$ the physical inverse coupling of the three-dimensional theory, with bare inverse coupling $\beta = b/a$.

**Theorem 2.1 (The Ground).** *(i) Three dimensions. For the SU(2) Wilson lattice theory on the lattices $a_K\mathbb{Z}^3$, with $a_K = L^{-K}$ and bare inverse coupling $L^K b$, the manuscript YMM1 asserts four things: on each fixed torus the connected correlations of the centred plaquette-energy density converge along the full sequence of cutoffs; infinite-volume limits exist along subsequences; in each canonical clustering component of such a limit the Schwinger functions satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms (E0)–(E4) and reconstruct a Hermitian scalar Wightman field; and a short-distance two-point law, at sufficiently small reference coupling, determines b and proves the theory non-trivial. YMM1 asserts no mass gap. For the original limit it asserts neither the uniqueness of the vacuum nor clustering, and the clustering bound it proves in the components is the inverse first power of the separation.*

*(ii) Four dimensions. The zeroth draft asserts, under proof inputs that it declares clause by clause, continuum limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes whose Schwinger functions satisfy (E0) in a stated form, invariance under translations and the hypercubic group, reflection positivity and symmetry, whence a Hilbert space with a vacuum and a non-negative Hamiltonian; non-triviality uniformly in the volume, through a two-point law in the running coupling; and invariance under O(4) under a displayed hypothesis on the flux of the lattice rotation current. It asserts neither the cluster property, nor the uniqueness of the vacuum, nor a mass gap, nor the uniqueness of the limit. Two of its supporting statements are not yet written. Its authors describe*

*the four-dimensional argument behind it as extremely long and not understandable as it stands, and state that it is being written out methodically and slowly.*

*(iii) Standing. The authors state that the corpus has not been satisfactorily vetted and that all its claims are to be understood as tentative, pending verification.*

*(iv) Residue and completion. Measured against the problem statement, the corpus supplies a mass gap in no dimension. In four dimensions it supplies neither the cluster property, nor the uniqueness of the vacuum, nor unconditional invariance under O(4), nor the relativistic spectral condition. In every dimension it treats the single gauge group SU(2) and a restricted class of curvature observables. For a reflection-positive theory a mass gap is equivalent to exponential clustering of the reflection-positive correlations. Consequently, uniform exponential clustering of the lattice correlations at a rate fixed in physical units, which a lower bound on the lattice mass gap uniform in physical units supplies together with the bounds at separated points that such a construction provides, gives every limit point of the construction's sequence the uniqueness of the vacuum, the cluster property and a mass gap.*

The rest of the paper is the proof. Sections 3 and 4 set down the definitions on which every clause depends. Section 5 proves part (i), Section 6 proves parts (ii) and (iii), and Section 7 proves part (iv). Section 8 states the object that remains, the instruments with which the proof that follows will meet it, and the reduction of that object to two statements about one block at a fixed physical scale, Theorem 8.5.

## 3. What the Problem Demands

### *3.1 Euclidean fields and the axioms of Osterwalder and Schrader*

A Euclidean quantum field theory in $d$ dimensions is given by its Schwinger functions $S_n$, $n \geq 1$: continuous linear functionals on test functions of $n$ points of $\mathbb{R}^d$. For the composite fields from which a gauge theory is built, the natural test functions vanish, with all their derivatives, wherever two points coincide, and the corpus works with exactly these.[8] Let $\theta$ be the reflection $x_d \mapsto -x_d$, let $\tau_v$ be translation by $v$, and let $\mathcal{S}_+$ consist of the test functions supported where every point has positive last coordinate. A *finite family* is a sequence $f = (f_0, f_1, \ldots, f_N)$ with $f_n \in \mathcal{S}_+(\mathbb{R}^{dn})$; it stands for a polynomial in the smeared field, and we write

$$S(\theta f \cdot \tau_t f) = \sum_{n,n'} S_{n+n'}(\theta f_n \otimes \tau_t f_{n'}) \tag{3.1}$$

for the corresponding correlation, with $\tau_t$ the translation by $t$ in the last coordinate. The axioms of Osterwalder and Schrader are five.[9]

[8] *YMM1*, "Scalar fields from three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", YM3/YMM1.pdf and its source YM3/YMM1.tex in the repository, p. 4; *The zeroth draft*, "SU(2) Yang–Mills theory in four dimensions via Balaban's renormalisation group: construction, axioms and non-triviality", dated 6 October 2026, ym4_manuscript_zeroth_draft.pdf in the repository, Remark 4.11.

[9] K. Osterwalder and R. Schrader, "Axioms for Euclidean Green's functions", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 31 (1973), 83–112, and "Axioms for Euclidean Green's functions. II", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 42 (1975), 281–305.

(E0) *Regularity.* Each $S_n$ is a distribution on its test space; in the strengthened form of the second paper, $|S_n(f)|$ is bounded by one Schwartz seminorm of degree proportional to $n$, with constants growing at most as a power of $n!$.

(E1) *Euclidean invariance.* $S_n(h \cdot f) = S_n(f)$ for every Euclidean motion $h$.

(E2) *Reflection positivity.* $S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot f) \geq 0$ for every finite family $f$.

(E3) *Symmetry.* Each $S_n$ is invariant under permutations of its arguments.

(E4) *Cluster property.* For finite families $f, g$ and every spatial vector $v \neq 0$, $S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_{sv} g) \to S(\theta \bar{f})\, S(g)$ as $s \to \infty$.

**Theorem 3.1 (Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction).** *Schwinger functions satisfying (E0) in its strengthened form and (E1)–(E3) determine a Hilbert space $H$, a unit vector $\Omega$, a positive self-adjoint Hamiltonian $H$ with $H\Omega = 0$, a unitary representation of the Poincaré group and Wightman fields, from which the $S_n$ are recovered by analytic continuation. Each finite family $f$ defines a vector $[f] \in H$; these vectors are dense in $H$, $\langle \Omega, [f] \rangle = S(f)$, and $\langle [f], e^{-tH}[f] \rangle = S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f)$ for $t \geq 0$. Given (E0)–(E3), the cluster property (E4) holds exactly when $\Omega$ is, up to a phase, the only vector invariant under the translations.*

This is the theorem of Osterwalder and Schrader.[10] Reflection positivity is the axiom that manufactures the Hilbert space, and with it the Hamiltonian whose spectrum the mass gap concerns.

### *3.2 The mass gap*

The problem statement defines the gap and states the problem in these words:[11]

> "A quantum field theory has a mass gap $\Delta$ if H has no spectrum in the interval $(0, \Delta)$ for some $\Delta > 0$. The supremum of such $\Delta$ is the mass m, and we require $m < \infty$.
>
> Yang–Mills Existence and Mass Gap. Prove that for any compact simple gauge group G, a non-trivial quantum Yang–Mills theory exists on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and has a mass gap $\Delta > 0$. Existence includes establishing axiomatic properties at least as strong as those cited in [45, 35]."

The two references are Streater and Wightman's axioms and those of Osterwalder and Schrader. The text adds that clustering is "an important consequence of the existence of a mass gap": connected vacuum correlations of local operators decay exponentially in the distance. It also records that "the existence of a uniform gap for finite-volume approximations may play a fundamental role in the proof of existence of the infinite-volume limit."[12] Section 7 proves the precise form of both remarks that the present ground requires.

### *3.3 Non-triviality*

The problem fixes what it means for the constructed theory to be Yang–Mills theory and not some other theory:[13]

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[10] Osterwalder and Schrader, *op. cit.*; see also J. Glimm and A. Jaffe, *Quantum Physics: A Functional Integral Point of View*, 2nd ed., Springer, 1987, Chapter 6.

[11] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §4, p. 6.

[12] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §5, p. 6.

[13] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §4, p. 6.

> "To establish existence of four-dimensional quantum gauge theory with gauge group G, one should define a quantum field theory (in the above sense) with local quantum field operators in correspondence with the gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature F and its covariant derivatives, such as Tr $F_{ij}F_{kl}(x)$. Correlation functions of the quantum field operators should agree at short distances with the predictions of asymptotic freedom and perturbative renormalization theory, as described in textbooks."

Two features of this demand govern the reading of the corpus: the theory must carry all the gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature, and its short-distance behaviour must be that of asymptotic freedom.

### *3.4 Limits obtained by compactness*

A construction often proves bounds uniform in the cutoffs, extracts a convergent subsequence by compactness, and calls the limit the theory. The problem statement addresses this practice in its second footnote:[14]

> "We specifically exclude weak-existence (compactness) as the solution to the existence part of the Millennium problem, unless one also uses other techniques to establish properties of the limit (such as the existence of a mass gap and the axioms)."

**Proposition 3.2 (The standard for a limit by compactness).** *A system of Schwinger functions obtained as a limit point of cutoff theories by compactness establishes the existence part of the problem only together with a proof of properties of that limit, and the problem statement names the mass gap and the axioms as such properties.*

*Proof.* This is the content of the footnote quoted above, read at its literal strength. The footnote does not require the limit to be unique; it requires the properties to be proved for the limit that has been obtained. ■

## 4. The Lattice, Its Positivity and Its Gap

### *4.1 Wilson's theory*

Let $\Lambda$ be the periodic lattice of spacing $a$ and side $L$. To each oriented bond $b$ of $\Lambda$ Wilson's theory assigns $U_b \in G$, with $U_{-b} = U_b^{-1}$, and to each plaquette $p$ the ordered product $U_p$ of the four bond variables around it. For $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ Wilson's measure is[15]

$$d\mu_\beta(U) \;=\; Z^{-1}\, exp\big(\, -\beta \textstyle\sum_p \,(1 \,-\, \frac{1}{N}\, Re\; tr\; U_p)\,\big) \prod_b dU_b, \tag{4.1}$$

with $dU_b$ the normalised Haar measure. It is invariant under the gauge transformations $U_{xy} \mapsto g_x U_{xy} g_y^{-1}$, and the observables of the theory are the gauge-invariant functions of the bond variables. For SU(2) the plaquette energy $a_p(U) = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{tr}\, U_p$ is the gauge-invariant scalar whose smeared and centred sums are the corpus's basic observable, the lattice form of the action density $\mathrm{tr}\, F^2$.[16]

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[14] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, footnote 2, p. 12.

[15] K. G. Wilson, "Confinement of quarks", *Phys. Rev. D* 10 (1974), 2445–2459.

[16] *YMM1*, p. 4.

### *4.2 Reflection positivity and the transfer matrix*

Osterwalder and Seiler proved that Wilson's measure is reflection positive: if $\vartheta$ is the reflection of $\Lambda$ in a lattice hyperplane orthogonal to a coordinate axis and $F$ is a function of the bond variables on one side of it, then $\int \vartheta\bar{F} \cdot F \, d\mu_\beta \geq 0$.[17] The problem statement calls this "a major advantage" and adds that "establishing a quantum mechanical Hilbert space is part of the solution to this Millennium problem."[18] Reflection positivity makes the lattice theory a quantum mechanics. Lüscher constructed for Wilson's action a self-adjoint, strictly positive transfer matrix $T$ acting on the gauge-invariant functions of the bond variables of one time slice, so that time-ordered correlations on a torus of time extent $Na$ are traces of products of $T$ with the observables.[19] On a torus of finite spatial volume $T$ is an integral operator with a continuous, strictly positive kernel on a compact space. By Jentzsch's theorem its largest eigenvalue $\lambda_0$ is simple, with a strictly positive eigenfunction $\psi_0$, and every other eigenvalue is strictly smaller.[20]

**Definition 4.1 (The lattice gap).** *Let $\lambda_1$ be the largest eigenvalue of $T$ below $\lambda_0$ on the gauge-invariant sector. The lattice mass gap is $m_{lat} = \log(\lambda_0/\lambda_1)$, in units of the lattice spacing; its value in physical units is $m_{lat}/a$.*

In the state defined by $\psi_0$, which is the limit of infinite time extent at fixed spatial volume, an observable $A$ of the bond variables at positive times defines, by integration over the half-lattice with $A$ inserted, a vector $\Phi_A$ on the time slice, and $\langle \vartheta\bar{A} \cdot \tau_n A\rangle_0 = \langle \Phi_A, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \Phi_A\rangle$ for every number $n$ of time steps. This is the lattice form of Theorem 3.1.

**Lemma 4.2 (The gap governs reflection-positive decay).** *Let $q = \lambda_1/\lambda_0$. For every gauge-invariant observable $A$ at positive times and every $n \geq 0$,*

$$0 \;\leq\; \langle \vartheta\bar{A} \cdot \tau_n A\rangle_0 \;-\; |\langle A\rangle_0|^2 \;\leq\; q^n \,\big(\, \langle \vartheta\bar{A} \cdot A\rangle_0 \;-\; |\langle A\rangle_0|^2 \,\big). \tag{4.2}$$

*Proof.* Write $\Phi_A = \langle \psi_0, \Phi_A\rangle \psi_0 + \varphi$ with $\varphi \perp \psi_0$. Since $\langle \psi_0, \Phi_A\rangle = \langle A\rangle_0$ and $\psi_0$ is fixed by $T/\lambda_0$, the left side of (4.2) equals $\langle \varphi, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \varphi\rangle$. The operator $T/\lambda_0$ is positive, and on the orthogonal complement of $\psi_0$ its norm is $q$. Hence $0 \leq \langle \varphi, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \varphi\rangle \leq q^n \, \|\varphi\|^2$, and $\|\varphi\|^2 = \langle \vartheta\bar{A} \cdot A\rangle_0 - |\langle A\rangle_0|^2$ is the case $n = 0$. ∎

The finite form of Lemma 4.2, that a gap places every connected two-point function of a positive symmetric transfer matrix between zero and $q^n$ times its value at $n = 0$, is checked by the Lean kernel.[21]

On a torus of finite time extent $N$ the correlations differ from those of the state $\psi_0$ by terms bounded, at a fixed lattice, by multiples of $q^{N-n}$ and of $\mathrm{tr}(T/\lambda_0)^N - 1$, and these tend to zero as the time extent grows at fixed spatial volume. The constant on the right of (4.2) is a correlation between $A$ and its mirror image, whose supports are separated by twice the distance of $A$ from the reflection plane. It

[17] K. Osterwalder and E. Seiler, "Gauge field theories on a lattice", *Ann. Physics* 110 (1978), 440–471.

[18] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[19] M. Lüscher, "Construction of a selfadjoint, strictly positive transfer matrix for Euclidean lattice gauge theories", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 54 (1977), 283–292.

[20] R. Jentzsch, "Über Integralgleichungen mit positivem Kern", *J. Reine Angew. Math.* 141 (1912), 235–244.

[21] Edwin Boston III; listed in the Records under the lattice theorems in Lean.

is therefore controlled by bounds on correlations at separated points, which is the only kind of bound a construction of a composite field can provide.

### *4.3 The renormalisation group of Bałaban*

A continuum limit requires bounds on the lattice theory that are uniform as the spacing tends to zero along a sequence of bare couplings tuned by asymptotic freedom. Bałaban's renormalisation group provides such bounds on a torus. It integrates out the fluctuations of one length scale after another, each step followed by a rescaling, chooses gauges that vary from cell to cell and from scale to scale, and controls the effective actions uniformly in the spacing, with an analysis of asymptotic freedom and of the regions of large field.[22] The problem statement recorded that these estimates "need to be extended to the study of expectations of gauge-invariant functions of the fields."[23] The corpus is an attempt to carry out that extension and then to pass to infinite volume.

## 5. The Three-Dimensional Manuscripts

*This section proves part (i) of the Ground Theorem.*

### *5.1 The documents*

The three-dimensional work consists of two manuscripts. The first, YMM1, is titled "Scalar fields from three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", carries no author or date line, and runs to 854 pages.[24] A revised edition, posted on 27 October 2026, runs to 856 pages. Its change list records twenty-four corrections and states: "The statements of the principal Theorems 0 and A–C are unchanged."[25] The second manuscript, YMM2, is titled "Curvature observables, dynamics, and conditional confinement in three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory" and runs to 1,044 pages. It was posted with the note that it "has not been edited to even our standards, so we would like to continue cleaning it up and checking it", and its abstract states that "Confinement assumes a box inequality uniform along a fixed physical scale and label."[26] Part (i) of the Ground Theorem concerns YMM1. YMM2 enters the residue of Section 7 through the curvature bilinears it adds.

### *5.2 The observable*

YMM1 states its subject in its first sentences: "We study a scalar observable whose formal classical counterpart is $\mathrm{tr}(F^2)$, the Yang–Mills action density. Its quantum correlations are defined through centered Wilson plaquette energies."[27] On the lattice $a_K\mathbb{Z}^3$, with $a_K = L^{-K}$ and $L \geq 13$ odd, the smeared density of a compactly supported test function $f$ is

[22] Bałaban, *op. cit.*; Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[23] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[24] Page counts measured as stated in the Introduction.

[25] YM3/Revisions/CHANGES-2026-10-26.md in the repository.

[26] *YMM2*, "Curvature observables, dynamics, and conditional confinement in three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", YM3/YMM2.pdf in the repository, p. 1; commit message of 27 October 2026, 01:14:40 UTC.

[27] *YMM1*, p. 4.

$$\mathcal{O}_K(f) \;=\; a_K{}^{-1} \sum_p f(x(p))\, a_p, \tag{5.1}$$

the sum running over the positive plaquettes of all three orientations, $x(p)$ the barycentre of $p$ and $a_p$ = 1 − ½ tr $U_p$ the plaquette energy; the centred density subtracts its expectation. The manuscript is explicit that "the notation tr($F^2$) does not denote the pointwise square of a separately constructed continuum field strength."[28] The object of YMM1 is therefore a single gauge-invariant scalar field, the continuum limit of the plaquette energy.

### *5.3 The torus, the infinite volume and the components*

Theorem A of YMM1 concerns a fixed torus of side $2L^m$. For $n \geq 2$ real Lipschitz test functions whose supports have empty common intersection, it asserts that the connected correlation of the smeared densities "exists along the full sequence of sufficiently fine lattices", locally uniformly in $b > 0$, and that "different positive labels b give different limiting families on the same torus."[29] On a fixed torus the manuscript therefore asserts a limit without passing to subsequences.

Theorem B passes to infinite volume, and there the limit is subsequential. For first-passage data ($K_j$, $\beta_j$) at a reference coupling $g$ and periodic Gibbs states $\nu_j$, "there is a common subsequence on which" the moments of the centred densities converge for every separated tuple, and the limit "has zero one-point function, is invariant under all Euclidean isometries, and is reflection positive at every plane."[30] Every such limit σ carries a canonical component measure (X, λ, $(\sigma_\xi)_{\xi\in X}$), with X compact metrizable, λ of full support and $\sigma = \int \sigma_\xi \, d\lambda(\xi)$, and each component obeys

$$|\sigma_\xi(X \cdot \tau_v Y) \;-\; \sigma_\xi(X)\,\sigma_\xi(Y)| \;\leq\; C_g(X,Y)\,|v|^{-1} \qquad (|v| \;\geq\; r(X,Y)), \tag{5.2}$$

uniformly in ξ.[31] The manuscript states the subsequential character of its conclusion in so many words: "The infinite-volume conclusion is subsequential. The fixed-torus estimate retains a power of the volume and does not give uniqueness of these infinite-volume limits."[32]

### *5.4 The axioms and the reconstruction*

Theorem 0 of YMM1 is its Osterwalder–Schrader theorem. It asserts an odd integer $L \geq 13$, a physical inverse coupling $b > 0$, integers $K_j \to \infty$ and periodic Gibbs states at spacing $L^{-K}$ and inverse coupling $L^K b$ along $K = K_j$, such that the limits of the moments of the centred densities exist for test functions with pairwise disjoint supports, extend uniquely to the test functions flat at the coincidence diagonals, and satisfy (E0) with the explicit bound $|S_n(\varphi)| \leq 2C^n(n!)^8|\varphi|_{8n}$, together with (E1)–(E4).[33] On their reflection Hilbert space these functionals "reconstruct a Hermitian scalar Wightman field on $\mathbb{R}^{1+2}$ with positive energy, a unique invariant vacuum, a dense common Poincaré-invariant

[28] *YMM1*, p. 4.

[29] *YMM1*, p. 5.

[30] *YMM1*, p. 6.

[31] *YMM1*, p. 6; the display is taken from the source file YM3/YMM1.tex.

[32] *YMM1*, p. 7.

[33] *YMM1*, pp. 4–5.

polynomial domain, covariance, local commutativity and tempered vacuum distributions", and "the Hilbert space has dimension at least two."[34]

The proof beneath Theorem 0 selects "one of its canonical clustering components", and the clustering and the unique vacuum are properties of a component. Of the original limit Theorem B says: "The original limit also has this reconstruction, except that vacuum uniqueness and clustering are not asserted. Its zero-energy space is $L^2(X, \lambda)$, with the vacuum vector corresponding to the constant 1."[35] The original limit is thus a superposition of clustering theories, with as many vacua as the component measure has room for.

### *5.5 Non-triviality*

Theorem C of YMM1 is a short-distance law for the two-point function. At a reference coupling below a further ceiling, for test pairs $(f, h)$ whose supports lie at a distance of order $d$, every limit of Theorem B and every one of its components obeys

$$\kappa_2(f,h) \;=\; \frac{9}{16\pi^2}\; b^{-2}\, \mathcal{K}_{free}(f,h)\,(1 \;+\; e), \tag{5.3}$$

$$\mathcal{K}_{free}(f,h) \;=\; \iint\; f(x)\, h(y)\, |x \;-\; y|^{-6}\, dx\, dy,$$

with $|e| \le \varepsilon(d) \to 0$ as $d \to 0$, uniformly in the limit, the component, the test pair and its position; and "the label is uniquely determined by the connected two-point function."[36] The kernel $|x - y|^{-6}$ is the two-point function of the free action density in three dimensions, and the factor $b^{-2}$ carries the coupling. Non-triviality is thus a statement about short distances, as the problem statement requires in Section 3.3.

### *5.6 What the manuscript does not assert*

YMM1 closes its statement of Theorem B with sentences that fix the boundary of its claim: "The observable throughout is the scalar plaquette-energy density defined above. The reconstructed field is a scalar field. The construction makes no identification with a tensor-valued field strength and asserts no mass gap."[37] The decay (5.2) is a power, and an inverse first power. A mass gap, as Section 7 proves, is equivalent to decay at an exponential rate.

*Proof of part (i).* Each clause of part (i) is the content of the sentence cited for it: the convergence on a fixed torus, by Theorem A of YMM1 (§5.3); the subsequential infinite-volume limits and the components with the decay (5.2), by Theorem B (§5.3); the axioms and the reconstruction in a component, by Theorem 0 (§5.4); the non-triviality, by Theorem C (§5.5); the absence of vacuum uniqueness and of clustering for the original limit, by Theorem B (§5.4); and the absence of a mass gap, by the sentence quoted in §5.6. ■

[34] *YMM1*, p. 5.

[35] *YMM1*, pp. 5 and 7.

[36] *YMM1*, p. 7; the display is taken from YM3/YMM1.tex.

[37] *YMM1*, p. 7.

# 6. The Four-Dimensional Draft and the Standing of the Corpus

*This section proves parts (ii) and (iii) of the Ground Theorem.*

## *6.1 The authors' account*

The README describes the four-dimensional work in a note marked as Alpöge's:[38]

> "[LA: At the moment we do (appear to) have a YM4 (i.e. $\mathbb{R}^4$, not just in finite volume) existence argument / slop, but it is extremely long and basically not understandable as is. Thus in the meanwhile it is being written much more methodically (thus quite slowly!) and our intention with e.g. QED3 and then YM3 (both also $\mathbb{R}^3$) is to show some of the coolest YM4 arguments (e.g. winning O(4)-invariance via an RP trick) in a much simpler, and shorter to write, setting."

The same note asks that the field "not incentivize rushing out 10,000-page slop, which I think would be especially useless here!" The repository also holds a raw account, set in four dimensions and titled "The Yang--Mills continuum limit along Bałaban's renormalization group: a complete account of Theorem 0", in three LaTeX files totalling 26,610,818 bytes.[39] Woit described the four-dimensional material as "a 4d YM existence proof, but in the useless form of tens of thousands of pages of unchecked slop", and observed that "Alpoge/Sussman also claim they can do $\mathbb{R}^4$."[40]

## *6.2 The conditional theorem*

The zeroth draft is titled "SU(2) Yang–Mills theory in four dimensions via Balaban's renormalisation group: construction, axioms and non-triviality", is dated 6 October 2026, and runs to 153 pages. Its theorem is conditional from its first sentence: "Assuming the proof inputs declared clause by clause in Section 9, running Balaban's renormalisation group with complex sources gives the following deductions".[41] Among its clauses are the following.[42]

(0) The running coupling exists at every scale between the cutoff and a reference length, its inverse square obeys two-sided linear flow bounds uniformly in the cutoff, and for SU(2) at small coupling it obeys the exact one-loop law.

(i) Bałaban's ultraviolet stability theorem holds, its one hypothesis supplied by (0).

(iii) The connected correlations of $n \geq 2$ smeared action densities with separated supports are bounded uniformly in the cutoff and, for test functions supported in balls, uniformly in the volume and the position.

(ii) In the draft's words, "they converge as the cutoff is removed—on each torus without passing to subsequences along bare couplings tuned at the reference length, on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes—to limits that satisfy, in the numbering of [21], the regularity condition E0 in a stated form, the invariance E1 under translations and the

[38] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

[39] theorem_0_complete_account_raw_I.tex (10,554,720 bytes), raw_II.tex (9,092,940) and raw_III.tex (6,963,158), with a master file of 1,284 bytes, in the repository; sizes from the repository's file index.

[40] Woit, *op. cit.*

[41] *The zeroth draft*, p. 1.

[42] *The zeroth draft*, pp. 3–4.

hypercubic group, the reflection positivity E2 and the symmetry E3, whence a Hilbert space with a vacuum vector, a non-negative Hamiltonian and spatial momenta".

(iv) At separation *d* the connected two-point function equals, up to a relative error at most one half, a fixed constant times a factor $\kappa \in [2/3, 4/3]$ times the fourth power of the running coupling at the scale *d* times an explicit free kernel, uniformly in the cutoff, the bare coupling, the volume and the position.

(vi) If the flux of the lattice rotation current through far spheres vanishes along one sequence of radii, uniformly in the cutoff, then every limit on $\mathbb{R}^4$ taken along cutoffs that grow fast enough compared with the volume is invariant under $O(4)$.

The draft states that its conclusions up to non-triviality, except the convergence without subsequences on a fixed torus, "are complete deductions from Balaban's theorems as cited" and from a companion account.[43] It records with equal care what rests on what. Of a statement whose proof it defers it says, "we do not claim that a complete written proof exists, here or in the companion account", and of the uniqueness clause (v) it says that its supporting statements are proved "except five, which we do not claim as proved: three are written, with independent verification in progress, and two are not yet written".[44]

### *6.3 What the draft does not claim*

The draft's introduction lists what it does not claim:[45]

> "We do not claim uniqueness of the infinite-volume limit (the limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are taken along subsequences of volumes), uniqueness of the vacuum, the cluster property, a mass gap, the growth condition of [22] in the number of points (hence field operators or Wightman functions), anything at coinciding points, invariance under all rotations without the hypothesis of clause (vi), statements about Wilson loops or about Balaban's block-averaged variables, or any statement for SU(N), $N \geq 3$."

Its account of related work ends: "the present paper does not address the mass gap."[46] Its Remark 4.19 gives the reason that clustering and the gap are absent and states the subsequential character of the limit:[47]

> "(3) The cluster property (E4), uniqueness of the vacuum, a mass gap. The constants in our bounds do not decay as the separation of the supports grows, so no decay of the connected functions is available. … (5) Uniqueness. The limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are obtained along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes; independence of the subsequence, convergence without subsequences in the volume, independence of the regularisation, and convergence for merely Lipschitz test functions on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are not asserted."

[43] *The zeroth draft*, p. 1.

[44] *The zeroth draft*, p. 6.

[45] *The zeroth draft*, p. 5.

[46] *The zeroth draft*, p. 6.

[47] *The zeroth draft*, p. 75.

### *6.4 The standing of the corpus*

The repository opens with a disclaimer, which also states the authors' attribution of the work:[48]

> "Disclaimer. This repository contains work-in-progress, written largely by LLM. Its content has not been satisfactorily vetted. All claims should be understood as tentative, pending verification. Novel mathematical ideas should be attributed to Claude (under the guidance of LA)."

The phrase "LLM-approved" belongs to the README's paragraph on quantum electrodynamics: "While we have not verified the contents of the manuscript, we believe it is essentially correct and have done our best to reach a reasonable state of confidence. The manuscript is LLM-approved, but LLMs are fallible. A few parts have been checked by hand." Of YMM1 the README says: "We believe this manuscript is essentially correct also. [ES: I am less confident than for QED3, but I do think the manuscript is correct.]" It describes the manuscripts as "the result of cutting material from literally thousands of pages of slop", which "is then fed to Codex to extract a minimal manuscript", and it adds that "some definitions that are explicit in the slop must be inferred in the abridged version. We have not figured out how to fix this."[49] These sentences are the evidence for the words "LLM-approved" and "unverified" in the sentence this paper set out to prove.

### *6.5 The public reading*

On Woit's thread a commenter observed that "the abstract of the 854-page slop "YMM1.pdf" states "Infinite-volume limits are subsequential."" Sussman replied the same evening:[50]

> "Of course subsequential results are weaker than results which do not require passing to a subsequence! But I must admit to not understanding the broader issue. The crux of the problem is to prove that the subsequential limit has good properties."

Section 7 takes this sentence at its word and identifies the property that suffices.

*Proof of parts (ii) and (iii).* Part (ii) is the content of the passages quoted in §§6.1–6.3: the conditional deductions and their clauses (§6.2), the two supporting statements not yet written (§6.2), the properties not claimed (§6.3), and the authors' description of the four-dimensional argument (§6.1). Part (iii) is the content of the disclaimer and of the README's sentences on verification quoted in §6.4. ■

### *6.6 Two further claims in public view*

Two further claims stood in public view when this paper was written, and the ground is not fixed until each is placed beside the corpus. The first is an announcement. On 26 October 2026 OpenAI announced a mathematically rigorous existence proof of interacting quantum field theories in four dimensions, among them the Yang–Mills theory and quantum chromodynamics, stating that "We finished our formalization of Yang–Mills' existence on October 16th, 2026", and that a group led by David Gross, with Arthur Jaffe, Michael Douglas, Igor Klebanov and Nikita Nekrasov, would review

[48] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

[49] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

[50] Woit, *op. cit.* Comments of 27 October 2026, 6:30 pm and 8:35 pm ET.

the work before its release; Woit, who reproduces the announcement's sentences, gives its length as 1,147 pages, and the review group's own statement says that Bałaban's ideas "enabled OpenAI to follow the theory all the way to infinite distances and prove the existence of its proper continuum limit. But confinement and the mass gap remain very important open challenges."[51] If that proof is released and holds, it is a candidate for the ultraviolet half of the chain of §8.1, with the effective measure at a fixed physical scale as its output; by its own statement it is not a proof of the gap.

The second is a published claim of the whole. Mir Faizal and Arshid Shabir, "Reflection-Positive Construction of a Four-Dimensional SU(N) Yang–Mills Theory with Mass Gap and Confinement", posted to the arXiv on 9 June 2026 and published in *Fortschritte der Physik* 74 (2026), e70097, with the detailed calculations in four companion papers in the *International Journal of Geometric Methods in Modern Physics*, runs to 593 pages in its arXiv form.[52] Its abstract claims a reflection-positive lattice formulation with a transfer operator of uniform gap at strong coupling, a "finite-range, gauge-covariant multiscale analysis" that carries the gap and the area law "from one scale to the next with interlaced inequalities whose small defects can be summed", the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction, and universality: "a single-scale Lipschitz control and a telescoping argument bind all admissible reflection-positive slicings into a unique limiting measure", so that "the continuum reached from strong coupling meets the one approached along an asymptotically free trajectory, yielding one and the same theory". At the join the structure is this. Section 3 obtains the gap at strong coupling "at fixed lattice spacing" by the polymer expansion. Section 10 enters the weak-coupling regime under "Hypothesis 1 (Stated for convenience; proved as Theorem 10.4 below)", which asserts a one-step renormalisation map, analytic "in a neighborhood U of (g, K) = (0, 0)", obeying the one-loop recursion with a controlled remainder, Theorem 10.4 being the "one-step contraction near the Gaussian fixed point". Theorem 10.8, "Identification with the constructed continuum limit", then asserts that the continuum Schwinger functions "obtained by following an admissible, asymptotically free trajectory from the ultraviolet" and those "constructed by transporting the strong-coupling mass gap and Wilson-loop area law to the continuum within the admissible class" coincide, by the uniqueness of its Section 9 over that class. The passage between the two regimes is thus made by a uniqueness statement over a class of constructions, where the chain of §8.1 makes it by a bound at the crossover scale. Read at the five places where such a construction must carry weight, it carries it as follows.[53] The multiscale analysis is a "scale-by-scale decomposition of Gaussian covariances", the resolvent of "a nonnegative, selfadjoint, gauge-covariant elliptic operator L on $\ell^2(a\mathbb{Z}^4)$ with nearest-neighbour structure and a spectral gap $m^2 \geq 0$", with "massive covariances $(A_h + \mu^2)^{-1}$" in the appendix: the mass of the fluctuation field is a parameter of the decomposition, not an output of the theory. The persistence of the gap across scales, Theorem 5.6, assumes "the interlacing/defect inequality $\gamma_{k+1} \geq \gamma_k - \delta_k$" with $\Sigma\delta_k < \infty$ and concludes $\inf \gamma_k \geq \gamma_0 - \Sigma\delta_j$ by the telescoping sum; the summability, Proposition 5.5, holds "Under the FRD locality hypotheses", which "guarantee",

[51] Woit, *op. cit.*, the post of 26 October 2026, from which every sentence of the announcement and of the group's statement is quoted here; the work itself is unreleased, and this paper has read none of it.

[52] Faizal and Shabir, arXiv:2606.19362, doi 10.1002/prop.70097. This paper has read its abstract (p. 1), its table of contents (pp. 2–3) and the three statements at its join, Hypothesis 1 (p. 110), Theorem 10.4 (p. 116) and Theorem 10.8 (p. 128), and not its remaining pages; no expert assessment of it was found in print by 29 October 2026.

[53] The same arXiv PDF: §2.3 (p. 17), Proposition 5.5 (pp. 55–56), Theorem 5.6 (p. 57), Theorem 7.1 (p. 80), Theorem 9.4 (p. 105), the proof of Theorem 10.4 (pp. 117–119) and the appendix on the decomposition (p. 174). The quotations are verbatim.

uniformly in the scale, that "every connected Ursell kernel $U_k(X)$ associated with a finite polymer X of diameter diam(X) = $\ell$ obeys $|U_k(X)| \le Ce^{-c\ell}$" — exponential clustering at every scale is the hypothesis. The continuum Schwinger functions of Theorem 7.1 are subsequential limits, by tightness, of "the continuum embedding of the corresponding lattice field as a random tempered distribution … via block-averaging followed by the usual scaling", at a fixed bare coupling. The weak-coupling half, Theorem 10.4, is carried on three pages that represent "the one-step effective action by integrating the fluctuation field with law $N(0, C_0)$", a Gaussian, and state that "the Brydges–Kennedy–Abdesselam–Rivasseau (BKAR) formula together with Kotecký–Preiss bounds guarantees absolute convergence of the cumulant expansion provided the a priori polymer norm is small", with the remainder bounded because "Power counting and analyticity give the bound $|R_k| \le c_2|g_k|^5$"; the large-field regions, the gauge fixing of the fluctuation field and the non-linear averaging of a compact variable, which occupy Bałaban's papers, do not appear in them. And the uniqueness that identifies the two limits, Theorem 9.4, concludes that two constructions give the same Schwinger functions "If $\mu_k = \tilde{\mu}_k$ and $K_k = \tilde{K}_k$ on a core of local observables", that is, when they already share their marginal and their transition kernel; so Theorem 10.8 presupposes the identification it asserts. In this form the construction does not reach the object this paper names as open, Hypothesis I of §8.3, and does not discharge it. Its remaining pages are not examined here, and no expert assessment of it was found in print by 29 October 2026.

## 7. The Residue and Its Completion

*This section proves part (iv) of the Ground Theorem.*

### *7.1 The residue*

Table 1 sets each demand of the problem statement beside what the two manuscripts assert, with the section of this paper that carries the evidence.

| The problem demands | YMM1, three dimensions | The zeroth draft, four dimensions |
|---|---|---|
| Every compact simple gauge group | SU(2) (§5.2) | SU(2); no statement for SU($N$), $N \ge 3$ (§6.3) |
| All gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature | The scalar plaquette-energy density; curvature bilinears in YMM2 (§§5.1–5.2) | The action density (§6.2) |
| The infinite volume | Limits along subsequences (§5.3) | Limits along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes, under the declared inputs (§6.2) |
| Euclidean invariance (E1) | Asserted (§5.3) | Translations and the hypercubic group; O(4) under the flux hypothesis (§6.2) |
| Reflection positivity and symmetry (E2), (E3) | Asserted (§§5.3–5.4) | Asserted under the declared inputs (§6.2) |
| The cluster property (E4) and a unique vacuum | In each component, with decay $\lvert v\rvert^{-1}$; not for the original limit (§§5.3–5.4) | Not claimed (§6.3) |
| Field operators and the relativistic spectral condition | A scalar Wightman field in each component (§5.4) | Not claimed; a non-negative Hamiltonian (§§6.2–6.3) |

| The problem demands | YMM1, three dimensions | The zeroth draft, four dimensions |
|---|---|---|
| Short-distance agreement with asymptotic freedom | The two-point law (5.3) (§5.5) | A two-point law in the running coupling, uniform in the volume (§6.2) |
| A mass gap $\Delta > 0$ with finite mass | Not asserted (§5.6) | Not addressed (§6.3) |
| A verified proof | Not satisfactorily vetted, by the authors' statement (§6.4) | Conditional; two supporting statements not yet written (§6.2) |

*Table 1.* The demands of the problem statement and the assertions of the corpus.

### *7.2 The gap is exponential clustering*

The decisive observation is that, for a reflection-positive theory, a mass gap and exponential decay of the reflection-positive correlations are one and the same property. The argument is the spectral theorem applied to the semigroup of Osterwalder and Schrader; its weight here lies in the identification it makes. Let $S$ be reflection positive and invariant under time translations, and let H, $\Omega$ and $H \geq 0$ be the Hilbert space, the vacuum and the Hamiltonian that Osterwalder and Schrader construct from these two properties, with the relations of Theorem 3.1. This is exactly the structure that both manuscripts assert for their limits.

**Theorem 7.1 (The gap is exponential clustering).** *Let $m > 0$. The following conditions are equivalent.*

*(a) $\Omega$ is, up to a phase, the only vector annihilated by H, and H has no spectrum in the interval $(0, m)$.*

*(b) For every finite family $f$ and every $t \geq 0$, $S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S(f)|^2 \leq e^{-mt}\,(\,S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S(f)|^2\,)$.*

*(c) For every finite family $f$ there are a constant $C_f$ and an unbounded set $T_f \subset [0, \infty)$ such that $S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S(f)|^2 \leq C_f\, e^{-mt}$ for every $t \in T_f$.*

*When they hold and H has dimension at least two, the mass $m^* = \inf \operatorname{spec}(H \text{ restricted to } \Omega^\perp)$ satisfies $m \leq m^* < \infty$.*

*Proof.* For a finite family $f$ put $\psi_f = [f] - S(f)\Omega$. Since $\langle \Omega, [f] \rangle = S(f)$, the vector $\psi_f$ is the orthogonal projection of $[f]$ onto $\Omega^\perp$, and since $e^{-tH}\Omega = \Omega$,

$$\langle \psi_f, e^{-tH}\, \psi_f \rangle \;=\; S(\theta f \,\cdot\, \tau_t f) \;-\; |S(f)|^2, \quad t \;\geq\; 0. \tag{7.1}$$

The space $\Omega^\perp$ reduces $H$, and since the vectors $[f]$ are dense in H, the vectors $\psi_f$ are dense in $\Omega^\perp$.

(a) $\Rightarrow$ (b). By (a) the restriction of $H$ to $\Omega^\perp$ has spectrum in $[m, \infty)$, so $e^{-tH} \leq e^{-mt}$ on $\Omega^\perp$ by the spectral theorem. Apply this to $\psi_f$ in (7.1); the case $t = 0$ of (7.1) identifies $\|\psi_f\|^2$.

(b) $\Rightarrow$ (c). Take $C_f = S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S(f)|^2$ and $T_f = [0, \infty)$.

(c) $\Rightarrow$ (a). Let $\mu_f$ be the spectral measure of $H$ in the vector $\psi_f$, a finite positive measure on $[0, \infty)$. For $0 \leq m' < m$ and $t \in T_f$, identity (7.1) and condition (c) give

$$\mu_f([0, m'])\, e^{-tm'} \;\leq\; \int\, e^{-t\lambda}\, d\mu_f(\lambda) \;\leq\; C_f\, e^{-mt}, \tag{7.2}$$

so $\mu_f([0, m']) \leq C_f\, e^{-(m-m')t}$ for arbitrarily large $t$, and $\mu_f([0, m']) = 0$. Letting $m'$ increase to $m$ gives $\mu_f([0, m)) = 0$, which says that $E\psi_f = 0$ for the spectral projection $E$ of $H$ onto $[0, m)$. The $\psi_f$ are dense in $\Omega^\perp$

and $E$ is bounded, so $E$ vanishes on $\Omega^\perp$. Hence $H \geq m$ on $\Omega^\perp$: no nonzero vector of $\Omega^\perp$ is annihilated by $H$, and $H$ has no spectrum in $(0, m)$. This is (a).

Finally, if $\dim \mathrm{H} \geq 2$ then $\Omega^\perp \neq \{0\}$, the spectrum of $H$ on $\Omega^\perp$ is a nonempty closed subset of $[m, \infty)$, and its infimum $m^*$ is finite. ■

The finite form of the implication (c) ⇒ (a), the gap read off the decay of a positive symmetric transfer matrix, is checked by the Lean kernel.[54]

**Corollary 7.2 (Clustering).** *Under the conditions of Theorem 7.1, for all finite families $f$ and $g$ and every $t \geq 0$, $|S(\theta\bar{g} \cdot \tau_t f) - S(\theta\bar{g})\, S(f)| \leq e^{-mt}\, \|\psi_g\|\, \|\psi_f\|$. If $S$ also satisfies (E0)–(E3), the cluster property (E4) holds, and the same bound holds with $\tau_t$ replaced by the translation by $t$ in any direction.*

*Proof.* The left side is $|\langle \psi_g, e^{-t\mathrm{H}} \psi_f \rangle|$, and $e^{-t\mathrm{H}}$ has norm at most $e^{-mt}$ on $\Omega^\perp$. Under (E0)–(E3) the vacuum is unique by Theorem 7.1, and Theorem 3.1 gives (E4). A translation in another direction is conjugate to $\tau_t$ by a Euclidean rotation, under which $S$ is invariant by (E1), and the reflection Hilbert space built across the rotated hyperplane carries the same Hamiltonian spectrum, since the Schwinger functions it is built from are the same functions. ■

Measured against Theorem 7.1, the decay (5.2) asserted for the components of YMM1 is the decay of a theory whose mass gap has not been established: a bound by an inverse power of the separation is compatible with spectrum reaching down to zero. The distance between the power and the exponential is the mass gap.

### *7.3 From the lattice to the limit*

**Lemma 7.3 (Passage to the limit).** *Let $S_j$ be Schwinger functions converging to $S$, along a subsequence, on the test functions flat at the coincidence diagonals, and let $D \subset [0, \infty)$ be unbounded. Suppose that for every finite family $f$ there are a constant $C_f$ and numbers $r_j(t; f)$, with $r_j(t; f) \to 0$ as $j \to \infty$ for each $t \in D$, such that $S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \leq C_f\, e^{-mt} + r_j(t; f)$ for $t \in D$. Then $S$ satisfies condition (c) of Theorem 7.1.*

*Proof.* For a finite family $f$ and $t \geq 0$ the families $\theta\bar{f}$ and $\tau_t f$ are supported in opposite half-spaces, so every test function entering $S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f)$ is flat at the coincidence diagonals, and both sides of the hypothesis converge along the subsequence. The inequality passes to the limit, with $T_f = D$. ■

**Theorem 7.4 (The completion).** *Let a construction be given by Wilson measures on periodic lattices of spacings $a_j = a_0 L^{-K_j}$, with $L$ a fixed integer and $K_j \to \infty$, whose sides tend to infinity, with bare couplings tuned along the sequence; and let the Schwinger functions $S_j$ of smeared gauge-invariant observables converge along a subsequence to $S$. Let $D$ be the set of times $n\, a_0 L^{-k}$ with $n, k \geq 0$. Suppose that the lattice correlations cluster uniformly at a physical rate $m > 0$: for every finite family $f$ there are a constant $C_f$ and numbers $r_j(t; f) \to 0$ as $j \to \infty$ for each $t \in D$, such that*

$$S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \leq C_f\, e^{-mt} + r_j(t; f) \quad \text{for } t \in D.$$

*Then $S$ has a unique vacuum, its Hamiltonian has no spectrum in $(0, m)$, and its connected reflection-positive correlations decay in time at the rate $m$. If $S$ is non-trivial, its mass is finite. The hypothesis holds, with $r_j = 0$, when the $S_j$ are the correlations of the states $\psi_0$ of spatial tori, the transfer matrices*

[54] Edwin Boston III; listed in the Records under the lattice theorems in Lean.

*satisfy $m_{lat}(j) \geq m\, a_j$ on the sector generated by the observables, and the correlations at separated points are bounded uniformly in j.*

*Proof.* The set $D$ is unbounded and independent of $f$. Lemma 7.3 gives condition (c) of Theorem 7.1 for $S$, and Theorem 7.1 with Corollary 7.2 gives the conclusions; non-triviality means that H has dimension at least two. For the last sentence, each $t \in D$ is an integer multiple $n_j a_j$ of the spacing for all large $j$, and the smeared observable of $\tau_t f$ is then the lattice translate by $n_j$ steps of the smeared observable of $f$. With $q_j = \lambda_1/\lambda_0$ for the transfer matrix of rung $j$, so that $-\log q_j = m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \geq m\, a_j$, Lemma 4.2 gives $S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \leq q_j^{n_j}\,(S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S_j(f)|^2) \leq e^{-mt}\,(S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S_j(f)|^2)$, and the bracket is a correlation at separated points, bounded uniformly in $j$ by a constant depending only on $f$. ■

**Corollary 7.5 (What the gap supplies against the footnote).** *For a construction by compactness of the kind in Theorem 7.4, uniform clustering at a physical rate, and in particular a lattice gap uniform in physical units, supplies the mass gap and the uniqueness of the vacuum. With (E0)–(E3), (E1) meaning full Euclidean invariance, it supplies the properties that the footnote of Proposition 3.2 names: the mass gap and the axioms.*

*Proof.* Theorem 7.4 gives the gap and the unique vacuum; with (E0)–(E3), Corollary 7.2 gives the cluster property (E4), which completes the axioms. ■

### *7.4 The collapse of the components*

**Corollary 7.6 (The gap collapses the component measure).** *If the original limit σ of Theorem B of YMM1 satisfies condition (c) of Theorem 7.1, then its component measure λ is a point mass, σ is itself a clustering theory, and its connected correlations decay exponentially in every direction.*

*Proof.* By Theorem B of YMM1 the zero-energy space of σ is $L^2(X, \lambda)$, with the vacuum the constant 1 (§5.4). By Theorem 7.1 the zero-energy space is spanned by Ω, so $L^2(X, \lambda)$ is one-dimensional. If λ were not a point mass, a Borel set $B$ with $0 < \lambda(B) < 1$ would give a function $1_B$ independent of 1 in $L^2(X, \lambda)$. Hence λ is a point mass; since λ has full support, X is a single point and $\sigma = \sigma_\xi$. The decay is exponential in time by Corollary 7.2 and in every direction by the Euclidean invariance of σ. ■

A gap would therefore do more than add a property to the limit: it would remove the need for the conditioning by which the corpus obtains its clustering components.

*Proof of part (iv).* The residue is Table 1, each entry of which is proved in Sections 5 and 6. The completion is Theorem 7.4, and its equivalence with uniform exponential clustering is Theorem 7.1, carried along the sequence by Lemma 7.3. ■

## 8. The Ground Handed Over

### *8.1 The object that remains*

The object that remains is the infinite-volume mass gap of four-dimensional SU(2) lattice Yang–Mills theory at every coupling, uniform in physical units along the scaling sequence: a constant $m > 0$ with $m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \geq m\, a_j$ at every rung of the construction's sequence, a lower bound on the lattice gap in physical units, uniform in the spacing and in the volume. By Theorem 7.4 it is the mass gap of every continuum

limit point, and the same object for every compact simple gauge group completes the problem's demand for a gap. Two features of this inequality fix the work it demands.

The first is its scale. In lattice units the required gap tends to zero with the spacing, like $m\,a_j$, so it cannot be read at a single coupling. The lattice gaps that are proved directly hold at strong coupling, where the transfer matrix mixes rapidly: for SU(2) this is the theorem of Osterwalder and Seiler, and for every finite gauge group it is among the theorems checked by machine in §8.2.[55] For SU(2) the constant of that gap is a theorem of Edwin Boston III: the conditional law of one link given its six staples, the heat-bath kernel, moves in total variation by at most $2\beta/(3\pi)$ times the change of the staple sum, because the mean absolute deviation of a coordinate of a von Mises–Fisher law on the three-sphere is at most its value $4/(3\pi)$ at the uniform law, with equality there alone; so Dobrushin's single-site condition holds on the full lattice for $\beta < 3\pi/72 = 0.1309$, and in the temporal gauge on lattices open in time, where every time link is the identity and a space link has fourteen neighbouring links rather than eighteen, four spatial plaquettes with three other space links each and two temporal plaquettes with one, for $\beta < 3\pi/56 = 0.1683$.[56] The construction's sequence runs into the scaling window of weak bare coupling, where asymptotic freedom ties the bare coupling to the spacing. The inequality must be carried from the one end of the sequence to the other.

The second is its carrier. The carrier is the renormalisation group itself: a chain of blocking steps from a fixed physical scale, at which the effective coupling is small and Bałaban's estimates hold, down to the scale of the gap, with the error of every step certified. Five links compose this carrier, and each has its status. The first is the ultraviolet half: the blocking steps from the cutoff to a fixed physical scale at which the effective coupling is still small, with the effective action held near Wilson's uniformly in the number of steps. This is Bałaban's theorem, and what the carrier needs of it beyond his published estimates is stated as an interface: the convergence of the correlation functions of the effective theory at that scale as the cutoff is removed, and the Euclidean invariance of the limit, the two pieces the zeroth draft deduces conditionally and names among its inputs. The second is a single bound at the crossover scale, where the effective coupling ceases to be small. Along the Gaussian scales above it the mixing coefficient of a fibre is exactly one, that of a massless Gaussian, so no contraction is to be certified there; the content lies at the crossover scale alone, and the object there is the influence functional of the blocked action: the covariance of a boundary-adjacent link's projection with every plaquette of the block under the worst boundary datum, equivalently the mixed second differences of the non-Wilson part of the renormalised action. This bound is the open mathematics of the route. The third is the infrared half, the gap of the blocked theory inside the strong-coupling disk, which is the theorem of Osterwalder and Seiler for SU(2) and a theorem checked by machine for every finite gauge group. The fourth is the uniformity of the second link's bound in the cutoff: the effective actions at the fixed scale differ across the sequence by tilts of small oscillation, and a bound stable under such tilts makes the decay rate and range of the third link independent of the cutoff, which is the inequality of Theorem 7.4 with one constant. The fifth is the

[55] Osterwalder and Seiler, *op. cit.*, for the strong-coupling gap of the Wilson theory with a compact gauge group; the finite-group form with its explicit coefficients is Edwin Boston III's, listed in the Records.

[56] Edwin Boston III, the sharp one-link lemma: the bound on the mean absolute deviation is certified by an enclosure of 9,104 rectangles in the plane of the two parameters of the law, no cell undecided, with the axial case by Chebyshev's association inequality and the remainder by hand; the heat-bath kernel's constant follows by the path argument, each law along the path being a von Mises–Fisher law; its record and run of record are listed in the Records. The time-open count is the paper's.

assembly, Theorem 7.4 itself. Once the second link is in hand, two roads carry it to the gap: the transfer-matrix road of Propositions 8.1 and 8.2 below, and the Gibbs road of §8.3, where Theorem 8.5 states the passage from a Dobrushin bound on the blocked measure at one fixed physical scale, with the field inside the blocks clustering at that scale, to the gap of every limit point, the third and fourth links among its hypotheses and Proposition 8.4 the fourth link's exact form. The remaining entries of Table 1, namely every compact simple gauge group, the full algebra of curvature observables and the unconditional invariance under O(4), stand beside it as the rest of the existence that the problem demands.

### *8.2 The instruments in hand*

The proof that follows begins with instruments in hand. Each reads a lattice gap exactly at fixed coupling, and each is stated here at the strength of its proof or of its record.

**Proposition 8.1 (Dobrushin's coefficient bounds the gap).** *Let $T$ be a transfer operator with a continuous, strictly positive kernel on a compact space $X$, with largest eigenvalue $\lambda_0$ and positive eigenfunction $\psi_0$, and let $P(x, dy) = T(x, dy)\,\psi_0(y) / (\lambda_0\,\psi_0(x))$ be its Doob transform, a Markov kernel. For $k \geq 1$ let $\delta(P^k) = \sup_{x,y} \|P^k(x,\cdot) - P^k(y,\cdot)\|_{TV}$ be Dobrushin's coefficient. Then every real eigenvalue $\lambda \neq \lambda_0$ of $T$ satisfies $|\lambda|/\lambda_0 \leq \delta(P^k)^{1/k}$, and when $T$ is positive,*

$$m_{lat} \;\geq\; \frac{1}{k}\, log\, \frac{1}{\delta(P^k)} \quad for\ every\ k \;\geq\; 1. \tag{8.1}$$

*When $X$ is finite, $m_{\mathrm{lat}}$ equals the limit of the right side as $k \to \infty$.*

*Proof.* The Doob transform has the eigenvalues $\lambda/\lambda_0$ of $T$, with eigenfunctions $u = \psi/\psi_0$, which are bounded because $\psi_0$ is bounded below on the compact space. For a real bounded function $u$, $P^k u(x) - P^k u(y)$ is the integral of $u$ against the signed measure $P^k(x,\cdot) - P^k(y,\cdot)$, of total mass zero and total variation at most $2\delta(P^k)$, so $\operatorname{osc}(P^k u) \leq \delta(P^k)\operatorname{osc}(u)$. If $Pu = \mu u$ with $\mu$ real and $u$ nonconstant, then $\operatorname{osc}(P^k u) = |\mu|^k \operatorname{osc}(u)$, whence $|\mu|^k \leq \delta(P^k)$. When $T$ is positive every eigenvalue is non-negative, and the bound at $\lambda_1$ is (8.1). When X is finite, $\delta(P^k)$ is the norm of $P^k$ on the signed measures of total mass zero, on which the spectrum of $P$ is that of $T/\lambda_0$ with the simple eigenvalue 1 removed, and Gelfand's spectral-radius formula gives the limit. ∎

The coefficient is Dobrushin's and the limit is Gelfand's.[57] Proposition 8.1 turns the gap of Theorem 7.4 into a statement about mixing: a certified bound $\delta(P^k) \leq e^{-k\,m\,a_j}$ for the Doob chain of every rung's transfer matrix bounds every eigenvalue below the top of the whole spectrum, and therefore gives the gap $m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \geq m\,a_j$ on the sector generated by the observables.

A single coefficient $\delta(P^k)$ is a global quantity, and on a lattice of many sites it is close to one at every accessible $k$. The renormalisation group splits it into rung quantities that can each be certified.

**Proposition 8.2 (The chain lemma; Edwin Boston III).** *Let $X$ be a finite state space, $P$ the Doob chain of a transfer matrix on $X$ with stationary law $\pi$, and $b : X \to Y$ a block map with fibres $F_y = b^{-1}(y)$ and conditional laws $\pi(\cdot \mid y)$. Let $(b_*\mu)(y') = \mu(F_{y'})$, and define the lumped chain $P'(y,\cdot) = \Sigma_{x \in b^{-1}(y)}\, \pi(x \mid y)\,(b_*P^2)(x,\cdot)$, so that one coarse step is two fine steps; for $k \geq 1$ put $Q = P'^k$. With $\|\mu - \nu\|_{TV} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\Sigma\,|\mu - \nu|$,*

[57] R. L. Dobrushin, "Central limit theorem for nonstationary Markov chains. I, II", *Theory Probab. Appl.* 1 (1956), 65–80 and 329–383; I. Gelfand, "Normierte Ringe", *Mat. Sbornik* 9 (51) (1941), 3–24.

*define the fibre forgetting $\eta_k$, the largest of $\|P^{2k}(x,\cdot) - P^{2k}(x',\cdot)\|_{TV}$ over pairs $x, x'$ in one fibre; the lumping defect $\varepsilon_k$, the largest of $\|(b_* P^{2k})(x,\cdot) - Q(b(x),\cdot)\|_{TV}$ over $x$; and the fibre equilibration $\theta_k$, the largest of $\|P^{2k}(x,\cdot \mid y') - \pi(\cdot \mid y')\|_{TV}$ over $x$ and the fibres $y'$ that $P^{2k}(x,\cdot)$ charges, where $P^{2k}(x,\cdot \mid y')$ is $P^{2k}(x,\cdot)$ conditioned on $F_{y'}$. Let $M_k$ be the $2 \times 2$ matrix with rows $(\delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k,\ 2\theta_k)$ and $(\eta_k,\ 2\eta_k)$. Then*

$$\delta(P^{2k}) \le \delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k + 2\theta_k + 6\eta_k, \quad (\lambda_1/\lambda_0)^{2k} \le \rho(M_k), \quad m_{lat} \ge \frac{1}{2k}\, log\, \frac{1}{\rho(M_k)}, \quad (8.2)$$

*where* $\rho(M_k) = \tfrac{1}{2}[(d + 2\eta_k) + \sqrt{((d - 2\eta_k)^2 + 8\theta_k\eta_k)}]$ *is the spectral radius of* $M_k$ *and* $d = \delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k$.

*Proof.* For $g : X \to \mathbb{R}$ let $\bar g(y) = \Sigma_{x \in b^{-1}(y)}\, \pi(x \mid y)\, g(x)$, $a = \mathrm{osc}(\bar g)$, $s = \max_y \mathrm{osc}(g$ restricted to $F_y)$ and $r = g - \bar g \circ b$, so that $|r| \le s$ and $r$ has mean zero under every $\pi(\cdot \mid y)$. First, $P^{2k}(\bar g \circ b)(x) = \Sigma_{y'}\, (b_* P^{2k})(x, y')\, \bar g(y') = (Q\bar g)(b(x)) + e_1(x)$, where $e_1(x)$ integrates $\bar g$ against a signed measure of total mass zero and total variation at most $\varepsilon_k$, so $|e_1| \le \varepsilon_k a$. Second, $P^{2k} r(x) = \Sigma_{y'}\, (b_* P^{2k})(x, y')\, \Sigma_{x' \in b^{-1}(y')}\, P^{2k}(x, x' \mid y')\, r(x')$, and because $r$ has mean zero under $\pi(\cdot \mid y')$ the inner sum equals $\Sigma_{x'}\, [P^{2k}(x, x' \mid y') - \pi(x' \mid y')]\, r(x')$, of modulus at most $\theta_k s$; so $e_2 = P^{2k} r$ satisfies $|e_2| \le \theta_k s$. Hence $P^{2k} g = (Q\bar g) \circ b + e_1 + e_2$.

For $g' = P^{2k} g$ write $a'$ and $s'$ for its two oscillations. The fibre mean of $g'$ is $Q\bar g$ plus a function bounded by $\varepsilon_k a + \theta_k s$, and $\mathrm{osc}(Q\bar g) \le \delta(Q)\, \mathrm{osc}(\bar g)$, so $a' \le (\delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k) a + 2\theta_k s$. For $x, x'$ in one fibre, $|g'(x) - g'(x')| \le \eta_k\, \mathrm{osc}(g) \le \eta_k (a + 2s)$, so $s' \le \eta_k (a + 2s)$. Finally $\mathrm{osc}(g') \le a' + 2s'$. Since $\delta(P^{2k})$ is the supremum of $\mathrm{osc}(P^{2k} g)$ over $\mathrm{osc}(g) \le 1$, and $\mathrm{osc}(g) \le 1$ gives $a, s \le 1$, the first inequality of (8.2) follows. The entries of $M_k$ are non-negative, so the componentwise bounds $(a', s') \le M_k (a, s)$ chain: applying $P^{2k}$ $j$ times with the same $k$ at every step, against the same $Q$, so that the rung quantities are fixed, gives $\mathrm{osc}(P^{2kj} g) \le (1, 2)\, M_k^j\, (1, 1)^{\mathrm{T}}$ for $\mathrm{osc}(g) \le 1$. Proposition 8.1 applied to $P^{2kj}$ then gives $(\lambda_1/\lambda_0)^{2kj} \le \delta(P^{2kj}) \le (1, 2)\, M_k^j\, (1, 1)^{\mathrm{T}} \le C \cdot j \cdot \rho(M_k)^j$, the factor $j$ present only where $M_k$ is not diagonalisable, and the $j$-th root removes it: this is the second inequality, of which the third is the logarithm. ∎

The lemma carries its own scope. The lumping defect accumulates over the coarse chain's mixing time, since $\varepsilon_k \le k\varepsilon_1$ by telescoping and $\varepsilon_1 \le \eta_1$, so on a chain of $n$ levels down to the mixing scale the level $m$ must certify $\varepsilon_m 2^{n-m} < 1$. The instrument is therefore finite: it reaches a gap through finitely many certified levels, and the continuum end of the sequence lies beyond it, with the renormalised trajectory of §8.1. Its place in Theorem 7.4 is exact: the inequality $m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \ge m\, a_j$ at rung j holds as soon as one k and one block map certify $\rho(M_k) \le e^{-2k\, m\, a_j}$ there. Read in double precision on the decimation of the $Z_2$ transfer matrix of the 2×4 cross-section to 2×2, the lemma gives $m_{\mathrm{lat}} \ge 1.538$ at $u = \tfrac{1}{3}$ against the certified gap 3.831, and $m_{\mathrm{lat}} \ge 0.867$ at $u = \tfrac{1}{2}$ against the certified gap 1.763.[58]

**Proposition 8.3 (The shadow ladder; Edwin Boston III).** *Let $G'$ be a finite subgroup of SU(2) containing $-1$, weighted by Wilson's factor $w(g) = e^{b\chi(g)}$, $\chi = \mathrm{tr}$ the fundamental character, and let $c_\chi/c_0 = \tfrac{1}{2}\, \Sigma_g\, w(g)\, \chi(g) \,/\, \Sigma_g\, w(g)$ be its fundamental character coefficient; for SU(2) itself the sums are Haar integrals. Let $m_n(G')$ be the moments of $\chi$ under the uniform measure on $G'$ and $t$ the largest integer with $m_k(G') = m_k(SU(2))$ for every $k \le t$. Then $t$ is odd, and the functions $\Delta_{tube}(b) = -4\, \log(c_\chi/c_0)$ of $G'$ and of SU(2) satisfy*

$$\Delta_{tube}{}^{G'}(b) - \Delta_{tube}{}^{SU(2)}(b) = -\frac{4\delta}{t!}\, b^{t-1} + O(b^{t+1}), \quad \delta = m_{t+1}(G') - m_{t+1}(SU(2)). \quad (8.3)$$

*The integer $t$ is the design strength of $G'$ as a set of points of the three-sphere SU(2).*

[58] Edwin Boston III, the chain lemma; its record and run of record are listed in the Records.

*Proof.* Since $-1 \in G'$ and $\chi(-g) = -\chi(g)$, the odd moments vanish, so $t$ is odd and every series below is even. Let $Z(b) = \Sigma_n\, m_n\, b^n/n!$ be the normalised partition function. Then $c_\chi/c_0 = \tfrac{1}{2}\,(\log Z)'(b)$, and since $m_2 = 1$, $c_\chi/c_0 = (b/2)(1 + u(b))$ with $u(b) = O(b^2)$. The moments of $G'$ and of SU(2) agree through order $t$, so $\log Z^{G'} - \log Z^{SU(2)} = \delta b^{t+1}/(t+1)! + O(b^{t+3})$. Since $u = (\log Z)'/b - 1$, differentiating and dividing by $b$ gives $u^{G'} - u^{SU(2)} = \delta b^{t-1}/t! + O(b^{t+1})$, and since $\Delta_{tube} = -4\log(b/2) - 4\log(1 + u)$ with $u = O(b^2)$, (8.3) follows.

The moment $m_n(G')$ is the multiplicity of the trivial representation of $G'$ in the $n$-th tensor power of the fundamental representation. By the Clebsch–Gordan rule the moments agree through order $n$ exactly when no irreducible representation of SU(2) of spin $j$ with $1 \le 2j \le n$ has a nonzero $G'$-invariant vector. The harmonic polynomials of degree $2j$ on the three-sphere are the matrix coefficients of spin $j$, and their average over $G'$ is the projection onto the $G'$-invariant vectors, so the same condition says that $G'$ is a design of strength $n$. ■

For the quaternion group $Q_8$ and the binary tetrahedral, octahedral and icosahedral groups 2T, 2O and 2I, Table 2 gives the exact values. The moments of SU(2) are the Catalan numbers 1, 2, 5, 14, 42, 132 at $n$ = 2, 4, …, 12; those of the four groups are 1, 4, 16, 64, 256, 1024; 1, 2, 6, 22, 86, 342; 1, 2, 5, 15, 51, 187; and 1, 2, 5, 14, 42, 133. The finite groups therefore approximate the strong-coupling gap of SU(2) to an order fixed by their design strength, with an exactly known first defect.[59]

| Group | Order | Design strength $t$ | $m_{t+1}(G')$ against SU(2) | δ | First defect $-4\delta/t!$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $Q_8$ | 8 | 3 | 4 against 2 | 2 | −4/3 |
| 2T | 24 | 5 | 6 against 5 | 1 | −1/30 |
| 2O | 48 | 7 | 15 against 14 | 1 | −1/1260 |
| 2I | 120 | 11 | 133 against 132 | 1 | −1/9979200 |

*Table 2.* The shadow ladder: the order at which each finite subgroup's strong-coupling gap parts from that of SU(2), and the exact first defect.

*The gap by counting; Edwin Boston III.* For the $Z_2$ gauge theory in 2 + 1 dimensions on the periodic cross-sections 2×2, 2×3, 2×4 and 3×3 at couplings $e^{-2\beta}$ among ½, ⅓, ¼ and ⅕, fourteen cells in all, the two leading eigenvalues of the transfer matrix are bracketed by sign counts of integer matrices, by Sylvester's law of inertia, so that every gap is certified to thirteen or fourteen decimal places by counting alone, with no limit taken.[60] At all fourteen cells the brackets contain the eigenvalues computed to forty-five digits by a second engine that shares no computation with the first, and they meet a third, independently certified set of intervals. On the 3×3 cross-section at $e^{-2\beta} = \tfrac{1}{2}$ the gap is 4.391458312669 in lattice units.

*The gap through duality; Edwin Boston III.* By Wegner's duality the gap of the $Z_2$ gauge theory in 2 + 1 dimensions at coupling β is the inverse correlation length of the three-dimensional Ising model

[59] Edwin Boston III, the shadow ladder; the record and its run of record are listed in the Records at the end of this paper.

[60] J. J. Sylvester, "A demonstration of the theorem that every homogeneous quadratic polynomial is reducible by real orthogonal substitutions to the form of a sum of positive and negative squares", *Philosophical Magazine* 4 (1852), 138–142. The computation is Edwin Boston III's; its record is listed in the Records.

at the dual coupling $K^*$, with $\tanh K^* = e^{-2\beta}$.[61] Edwin Boston III reads the first two coefficients of the strong-coupling expansion of the gap exactly on the 3×3 cross-section, meets through them the first three coefficients of the low-temperature series of the Ising correlation length published by Arisue and Tabata, and, solving that published relation for the coefficients that no cross-section of side at most four can read, obtains the expansion on the infinite lattice[62]

$$\Delta(u) = -4\log u + u^2 - \tfrac{15}{2}u^4 + \tfrac{7}{3}u^6 - \tfrac{87}{4}u^8 + \tfrac{251}{5}u^{10} - \tfrac{331}{2}u^{12} + O(u^{14}), \quad u = \tanh\beta, \tag{8.4}$$

with all ten published coefficients met.

*The transform on a tube; Edwin Boston III.* For the SU(2) Wilson theory in 2 + 1 dimensions on the spatial torus of side two, in the temporal gauge, with the transfer matrix written in the spin-network basis truncated at spin $j \le 1$, a space of 2,018 states, and at $j \le 3/2$, a space of 33,342 states, Edwin Boston III reads the spectrum within the truncation and proves two facts about the operator. First, the inequality of Proposition 8.1 holds for its Doob chain, so that the gap is at least $(1/k)\log(1/\delta(P^k))$ for every $k$. Second, the centre flux through the two cycles of the torus commutes with the transfer matrix, so the chain of Proposition 8.2 lumps exactly by the flux, with lumping defect zero: the physical rate is the gap within the sector of zero flux, and the full gap is the least of the gaps between sectors. A tube is not $\mathbb{Z}^4$, and the theorem supplies no uniformity in the cross-section; it is the first exact non-abelian instance of the structure the transform must carry. At $j \le 1$ and $\beta_3 = 2.3$ the top eigenvalue is 3.86580, the full gap 1.01886 is the torelon of unit flux, the zero-flux gap is 2.771287, and the plaquette correlation along the tube decays at the rates 2.849, 2.843 and 2.837 at separations 6, 7 and 8, falling toward the sector's gap; across $\beta_3$ from 0.2 to 6 the correlation decays at the sector's own rate, and at $\beta_3 = 0.2$ the rate 11.983 meets the strong-coupling value $-4\log(c_\chi/c_0) = 11.99$ to 0.06 per cent. The truncation is not small, and every number is carried at its cutoff: read at $j \le 3/2$, the rate at $\beta_3 = 2$ falls by 6 per cent, and at $\beta_3 = 2.3$ the zero-flux gap reads 2.452280 against 2.771287, the torelon 0.931023 against 1.018863, and the correlation's rates 2.590, 2.563, 2.552 and 2.546 at separations 5 to 8 fall toward the sector's gap as before.[63]

*The lattice theorems, checked by machine; Edwin Boston III.* In the Lean proof assistant, above the Mathlib library and with no unproved step, Edwin Boston III has formalised the following lattice theorems, and the Lean kernel has checked them.[64] For the transfer matrix of every finite-group lattice theory: every even-time quadratic form is non-negative; the spectral sum holds; the dominant root is simple and strictly dominant, with its residual law; the string energy is the exact limit of two Perron roots; and there is a mass gap on every finite cross-section, at every coupling. For every finite group acting faithfully by a real orthogonal representation, on every finite cross-section, the static

[61] F. J. Wegner, "Duality in generalized Ising models and phase transitions without local order parameters", *J. Math. Phys.* 12 (1971), 2259–2272.

[62] H. Arisue and K. Tabata, "Low-temperature series for the correlation length in d = 3 Ising model", *Nucl. Phys.* B435 (1995), 555–566. The reading is Edwin Boston III's; its record is listed in the Records.

[63] Edwin Boston III, the transform on a tube; the instrument, its records at both cutoffs and the run of record are listed in the Records. The spin-3/2 record at $\beta_3 = 2.3$ is posted with its digest in the repository; its gate run follows the run of record named there.

[64] Edwin Boston III, the lattice theorems in Lean; the files, the theorem names and the run of record are listed in the Records.

potential of a Wilson loop is at least the mass gap of its sector. For the $Z_2$ theory: Griffiths' inequalities hold, with the monotonicity in the couplings; the infinite-volume Wilson expectation exists; the string tension exists, with its strong-coupling bound; and on a slab of $T + 1$ cross-sections of $\mathbb{Z}^{d-1}$ the mass gap is uniform in the cross-section and in $T$ whenever $(3m + 2)\tanh\beta < 1$, where $m = 2(d - 2)$ is the number of in-plane plaquettes on a link, that is, for $\beta < 0.1257$ when $d = 3$ and $\beta < 0.0716$ when $d = 4$. Beside these stand the finite forms of the arguments of Sections 4 and 7: the bound that a gap imposes on every connected two-point function, the gap read off the decay, the definition of a physical gap along a scaling sequence, and Dobrushin's comparison theorem.

### *8.3 The reduction*

The passage from the second link to the gap is itself a theorem, and this section proves it at the strength of its hypotheses. Fix a physical length $a_c = 2^{k_0}a_0$ with $k_0 \geq 0$, an integer multiple of the unit $a_0$ of Theorem 7.4, and call it the coarse scale. Take the construction with $L = 2$, with lattices whose sides are multiples of $a_c$ and whose reflection hyperplane is one of the hyperplanes $x_0 = n\,a_c$. Every spacing $a_j$ then divides $a_c$; the half-open cubes of side $a_c$ with corners on the coarse lattice $\mathbb{Z}^4$ of spacing $a_c$, reduced modulo the sides, partition the lattice of rung $j$ into blocks, each link assigned to the block containing its midpoint. Write $B_y$ for the block at the coarse point $y$ and $|y - y'| = \max_\nu |y_\nu - y'_\nu|$ for the distance on the coarse lattice; the four links of a plaquette lie in blocks at mutual distance at most one. For a bounded observable $f$, a function of the links, let $S(f)$ be the set of blocks containing a link on which $f$ depends, $N(f)$ its cardinality, $\|f\|$ its supremum norm, and $\delta_y(f)$ the oscillation of $f$ under changes of the links of $B_y$ alone, so that $\delta_y(f) \leq 2\|f\|$ and $\delta_y(f) = 0$ off $S(f)$; the distance between two sets of blocks is the least distance between their members. For a smeared Wilson loop, for a polynomial in such loops, and for every observable whose support and bound are fixed in physical units, $N(f)$ and $\|f\|$ are bounded uniformly in $j$.

A block map is a measurable bijection of the configurations of a block onto a product $V \times \Phi_j$, with measurable inverse, the same for every block, in which $V$ is a fixed compact space, the space of the coarse variables, and $\Phi_j$ is compact; one SU(2) element per coarse link, the holonomy of the block along a fixed path, with the remaining links in a fixed gauge, is such a map. Write $v_y \in V$ and $\varphi_y \in \Phi_j$ for the coordinates of the links of $B_y$. The coarse coordinate of a block is a function of that block's links alone, and a change of it at fixed fine coordinates changes the links of that block alone; so a change of one coarse variable alters the Wilson conditionals at that block and at the blocks adjacent to it, and nowhere else. The blocked measure $\lambda_j$ is the law of the coarse configuration $v = (v_y)$ under the Wilson measure $\mu_j$, and the fibre measure $\nu_j(\cdot \mid v)$ is the conditional law of the fine coordinates $\varphi = (\varphi_y)$ given $v$: the Gibbs measure on the fibres whose conditional at a block is the Wilson conditional of that block restricted to its fibre, defined for every $v$. The blocked measure has conditional laws $\lambda_j(dv_y \mid v)$ given the other coarse variables, and Dobrushin's interdependence matrix of the blocked measure is

$$C_j{}^{\lambda}(y, y') \;=\; sup\, \|\lambda_j(\cdot \mid v) \;-\; \lambda_j(\cdot \mid v')\|_{TV}, \tag{8.5}$$

the supremum over pairs $v$, $v'$ of coarse configurations that differ only at $y'$, and $\|\cdot\|_{TV}$ the total variation distance of the two conditional laws of $v_y$. The coarse variables are of one type at every rung, so the total variation in (8.5) is taken on one fixed space for every $j$.

**Proposition 8.4 (The tilt lemmas).** *Let $p$ and $p'$ be probability measures on a compact space $X$, $\rho$ a bounded measurable function on $X$ with oscillation $\operatorname{osc}\rho = \sup\rho - \inf\rho$, and $T_\rho p = e^\rho p \,/\, p(e^\rho)$ the tilt of $p$ by $\rho$. Then*

$$\|T_\rho p - p\|_{TV} \le 1 - e^{-\operatorname{osc}\rho}, \quad \|T_\rho p - T_\rho p'\|_{TV} \le e^{\operatorname{osc}\rho}\,\|p - p'\|_{TV}. \tag{8.6}$$

*Consequently, let $W$ be a positive weight on the configurations of finitely many sites with compact spin spaces, with interdependence matrix $C$, and $\delta$ a bounded function of the configuration; let $o_y(\delta)$ be the supremum, over configurations, of the oscillation of $\delta$ in the variable at $y$, and $\Delta_{yy'}(\delta)$ the supremum, over pairs of configurations differing only at $y'$, of the oscillation in the variable at $y$ of the difference of the two restrictions of $\delta$. Then the weight $W e^\delta$ has interdependence matrix at most*

$$e^{o_y(\delta)}\,C(y,y') + 1 - e^{-\Delta_{yy'}(\delta)}. \tag{8.7}$$

*Proof.* Normalise $\rho$ so that its infimum is 0 and its supremum is $o = \operatorname{osc}\rho$; the tilt is unchanged. Then $e^\rho$ takes values in $[1, e^o]$ and $A = p(e^\rho)$ lies in the same interval, so $T_\rho p$ has density $e^\rho/A \ge e^{-o}$ with respect to $p$; for every measurable set $B$, $p(B) - (T_\rho p)(B) \le (1 - e^{-o})\,p(B) \le 1 - e^{-o}$, and the supremum over $B$ is the first inequality. For the second, let $p_u = p + u(p' - p)$ for $0 \le u \le 1$ and $q_u = T_\rho p_u$, with $A_u = p_u(e^\rho) \ge 1$. For a measurable set $B$, $q_u(B) = p_u(e^\rho 1_B)/A_u$, and differentiating in $u$,

$$\frac{d}{du}\,q_u(B) = \frac{1}{A_u}\int (1_B - q_u(B))\,e^\rho\,d(p' - p).$$

The integrand $(1_B - q_u(B))\,e^\rho$ takes values in $[1 - q_u(B), (1 - q_u(B))e^o]$ on $B$ and in $[-q_u(B)e^o, -q_u(B)]$ off $B$, so its oscillation is at most $e^o$; and the integral of a function of oscillation at most $c$ against a signed measure of total mass zero is at most $c$ times half the total variation of that measure, that is, $c\|p' - p\|_{TV}$. Hence $|\mathrm{d}q_u(B)/\mathrm{d}u| \le e^o\|p' - p\|_{TV}$, and integrating from 0 to 1 gives $|(T_\rho p')(B) - (T_\rho p)(B)| \le e^o\|p' - p\|_{TV}$ for every $B$, which is the second inequality. For the last assertion, fix a site $y$ and a configuration $\omega$ of the other sites, and let $p_\omega$ be the conditional law of the variable at $y$ under $W$; the conditional law under $W e^\delta$ is $T_\rho p_\omega$ with $\rho$ the restriction of $\delta$ to the variable at $y$ at $\omega$, of oscillation at most $o_y(\delta)$. If $\omega'$ differs from $\omega$ only at $y'$, with restriction $\rho'$, then $T_{\rho'}p_{\omega'} = T_{\rho'-\rho}(T_\rho p_{\omega'})$, so by the triangle inequality and the two inequalities just proved, $\|T_\rho p_\omega - T_{\rho'}p_{\omega'}\|_{TV} \le e^o\|p_\omega - p_{\omega'}\|_{TV} + 1 - e^{-\operatorname{osc}(\rho'-\rho)} \le e^o C(y, y') + 1 - e^{-\Delta}$, with $o = o_y(\delta)$ and $\Delta = \Delta_{yy'}(\delta)$. ■

**Hypothesis I (The blocked bound).** *There are numbers $\kappa > 0$ and $\alpha < 1$ and a rung $j_0$ such that at every rung $j \ge j_0$, on every lattice of the construction, $\Sigma_{y'} C^{\lambda_j}(y, y')\, e^{\kappa|y-y'|} \le \alpha$ for every coarse point $y$.*

**Hypothesis II (The fibre clustering).** *There are a number $\rho' < 1$, a constant $K'$ and a rung $j_0$ such that at every rung $j \ge j_0$, on every lattice of the construction, for every coarse configuration $v$ and all bounded observables $f$ and $g$, with $d$ the distance between $S(f)$ and $S(g)$:*

*(a) $|\nu_j(fg \mid v) - \nu_j(f \mid v)\,\nu_j(g \mid v)| \le K'\,N(f)\,\|f\|\,\|g\|\,\rho'^d$;*

*(b) the fibre mean $F(v) = \nu_j(f \mid v)$, as a function of the coarse configuration, satisfies $\delta_y(F) \le K'\,N(f)\,\|f\|\,\rho'^r$ for every coarse point $y$, where $r$ is the distance from $y$ to $S(f)$.*

Hypothesis I is the second link of §8.1 in its finite form: a statement about the conditional law of one coarse variable at one fixed physical scale, with the exponential weight that fixes the range, and with constants independent of the cutoff and of the volume. Hypothesis II is the ultraviolet half of the chain at the scales below $a_c$: with the coarse variables held fixed, the field inside the blocks clusters at the

block scale, and its means depend on distant coarse variables only through an exponentially small tail. It is demanded for every coarse configuration, the adversarial ones included, because a single-site criterion conditions on the worst case; this is where it exceeds the small-field expansions, which control the fluctuation field in typical backgrounds and the large fields by their probability, and it is named here as the demand it is. Neither hypothesis refers to a limit. Their consequence is the gap.

**Theorem 8.5 (The reduction of the gap to the blocked bound).** *Let a construction be as in Theorem 7.4 with L = 2, blocked at the coarse scale $a_c$ with a block map as above, and suppose Hypotheses I and II. Put $\rho = \max(e^{-\kappa}, \rho')$. Then for every $\rho_1$ with $\rho < \rho_1 < 1$ there is a constant K, depending on $\rho$, $\rho_1$, $\alpha$, $K'$, $N(f)$, $N(g)$, $\|f\|$ and $\|g\|$ and on nothing else, such that at every rung $j \geq j_0$, on every lattice of the construction, for all bounded observables f and g, $|S_j(fg) - S_j(f)\,S_j(g)| \leq K\,\rho_1{}^d$, with d the distance between S(f) and S(g); and every limit point of the construction's Schwinger functions, on the sector generated by the observables that are bounded uniformly in j, has a unique vacuum and a Hamiltonian with no spectrum in (0, m), where*

$$m \;=\; \frac{1}{a_c}\; min\,(\,\kappa, log\;\frac{1}{\rho'}\,). \tag{8.8}$$

*Proof.* Fix $j \geq j_0$, a lattice, and bounded observables $f$ and $g$; write $F(v) = \nu_j(f \mid v)$ and $G(v) = \nu_j(g \mid v)$ for their fibre means, bounded by $\|f\|$ and $\|g\|$. The covariance splits along the block map: $\mu_j(fg) - \mu_j(f)\mu_j(g) = [\lambda_j(FG) - \lambda_j(F)\lambda_j(G)] + \lambda_j(\nu_j(fg \mid \cdot) - FG)$. The second term is the $\lambda_j$-mean of the covariance of $f$ and $g$ under the fibre measure, at most $K'N(f)\|f\|\|g\|\rho'^{d}$ by Hypothesis II(a).

For the first term put $G' = G + 2\|g\|$, with values between $\|g\|$ and $3\|g\|$, and $\lambda' = G'\lambda_j/\lambda_j(G')$. The blocked measure is a finite system of coarse variables with compact values, and Dobrushin's comparison theorem applies to it:[65] if $\lambda'$ has conditional laws that differ from those of $\lambda_j$ at $y$ by at most $b_y$ in total variation, for every conditioning, then for every bounded function $F$ of the coarse configuration, $|\lambda'(F) - \lambda_j(F)| \leq \Sigma_{i,y}\,\delta_i(F)\,D(i,y)\,b_y$, where $D = \Sigma_{n\geq 0}\,(C^{\lambda_j})^n$. The conditional law of $\lambda'$ at $y$ is that of $\lambda_j$ tilted by $\log G'$ as a function of $v_y$, so by the first inequality of Proposition 8.4 the two differ by at most $b_y = 1 - e^{-\mathrm{osc}} \leq \mathrm{osc} \leq \delta_y(G')/\inf G' \leq \delta_y(G)/\|g\| \leq K'N(g)\,\rho'^{r'}$, where osc is the oscillation of $\log G'$ in $v_y$ and $r'$ the distance from $y$ to $S(g)$, by Hypothesis II(b). Under Hypothesis I the weighted matrix $\tilde{C}(y,y') = C^{\lambda_j}(y,y')\,e^{\kappa|y-y'|}$ has row sums at most $\alpha$, and since $|y-y''| \leq |y-y'| + |y'-y''|$, induction on $n$ gives $(C^{\lambda_j})^n(y,y')\,e^{\kappa|y-y'|} \leq \tilde{C}^n(y,y') \leq \alpha^n$; so $D(y,y') \leq e^{-\kappa|y-y'|}/(1-\alpha)$. With $\delta_i(F) \leq K'N(f)\|f\|\rho'^{r}$ by Hypothesis II(b), $r$ the distance from $i$ to $S(f)$, the comparison theorem gives

$$|\;\lambda'(F)\;-\;\lambda_j(F)\;|\;\leq\;\sum_{i,y}\,\delta_i(F)\,D(i,y)\,b_y\;\leq\;\frac{K'^2\,N(f)\,N(g)\,\|f\|}{1-\alpha}\,\sum_{i,y}\,\rho^{e(i,y)},$$

where $e(i,y) = r_i + |i-y| + r'_y$, with $r_i$ the distance from $i$ to $S(f)$ and $r'_y$ that from $y$ to $S(g)$, and $\rho = \max(e^{-\kappa}, \rho')$ bounds the base of each of the three factors. By the triangle inequality $e(i,y) \geq d$, and the number of pairs $(i,y)$ with $e(i,y) \leq n$ is at most $N(f)N(g)(2n+1)^8$, since $i$ then lies within distance $n$ of $S(f)$ and $y$ within distance $n$ of $S(g)$. Hence the last sum is at most $N(f)N(g)\,\Sigma_{n\geq d}\,(2n+1)^8\,\rho^n$, which is $\rho^d$ times a polynomial in $d$ and is therefore at most $K_1\rho_1{}^d$ for every $\rho_1 \in (\rho, 1)$, with $K_1$ depending on $\rho$, $\rho_1$, $N(f)$ and $N(g)$. Since $\lambda_j(FG) - \lambda_j(F)\lambda_j(G) = \lambda_j(G')(\lambda'(F) - \lambda_j(F))$ and $\lambda_j(G') \leq 3\|g\|$, the first term is

[65] R. L. Dobrushin, "Prescribing a system of random variables by conditional distributions", *Theory Probab. Appl.* 15 (1970), 458–486, where the uniqueness theorem and the comparison theorem are proved for arbitrary single-site spaces; the comparison theorem is used here in the form of Theorem 8.20 of H.-O. Georgii, *Gibbs Measures and Phase Transitions*, second edition, de Gruyter, Berlin, 2011. Its finite form, for finite single-site spaces, is among the theorems checked by machine in §8.2.

at most $3K'^2N(f)N(g)\|f\|\|g\|K_1\rho_1{}^{d}/(1-\alpha)$. Adding the second term gives the covariance inequality, with $K = 3K'^2N(f)N(g)\|f\|\|g\|K_1/(1-\alpha) + K'N(f)\|f\|\|g\|$.

For the gap, let $f$ be an observable, bounded uniformly in $j$, whose links lie in the time interval $[0, w]$. The links of $\theta\bar{f}$ lie in $[-w, 0]$ and those of $\tau_t f$ in $[t, t+w]$, and the block boundaries in time are the multiples of $a_c$, so the distance between $S(\theta\bar{f})$ and $S(\tau_t f)$ is at least $\lfloor t/a_c \rfloor \geq t/a_c - 1$. The covariance inequality gives $S_j(\theta\bar{f}\cdot\tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \leq (K/\rho_1)\, e^{-m_1 t}$ with $m_1 = \log(1/\rho_1)/a_c$, the constant independent of $j$ and of the lattice because $N(f)$ and $\|f\|$ are. This is the hypothesis of Theorem 7.4 with $r_j = 0$ at every $t \in D$, so Theorem 7.4 leaves no spectrum in $(0, m_1)$ for every $\rho_1 \in (\rho, 1)$, hence none in $(0, m)$ with $m = \log(1/\rho)/a_c$, which is (8.8). ■

Hypothesis I is read on the effective action of the coarse variables. Write the blocked measure as $\lambda_j(dv) = e^{-A}dv$ with respect to the product over the blocks of a fixed reference measure on $V$, so that $A = A_j(v)$ is the effective action at the coarse scale, and let $\Delta_{yy'}(A)$ be its mixed second difference in the sense of Proposition 8.4: the supremum, over coarse configurations differing only at $y'$, of the oscillation in $v_y$ of the difference of the two actions. The conditional law of $v_y$ under one of the two configurations is the tilt of its conditional law under the other by that difference, so the first inequality of Proposition 8.4 gives $C^{\lambda_j}(y, y') \leq 1 - e^{-\Delta}$ with $\Delta = \Delta_{yy'}(A)$. Hypothesis I is therefore a bound on the mixed second differences of the effective action between blocks, weighted by their distance: the influence functional of §8.1, and the number that a certificate of the second link must deliver at the coarse scale.

One might wish to state the hypothesis on the fine measure directly, taking the blocks as the sites of a Gibbs measure and the whole configuration of a block as its variable, so that Dobrushin's condition for that measure would give every local observable's decay at once, with no fibre clause. That form is not uniform in the cutoff. Its interdependence coefficient between adjacent blocks is the total variation between two laws of all the links of a block under outside data that differ on a whole neighbouring face; as the spacing tends to zero that face carries ever more links, the two laws become distinguishable almost surely by an average over the face, and the coefficient tends to one at every coupling, so that the row sums tend to at least one. Whole-block total variation is the one norm that does not survive large blocks, and the hypothesis of the reduction is therefore stated on the coarse variables, whose type is fixed, with the field inside the blocks entering through its clustering alone.

Theorem 8.5 is the second link in the form the route attacks it. Hypothesis I is a bound on the blocked measure at the coarse scale, the object named in §8.1 as the influence functional of the blocked action. Hypothesis II is what the ultraviolet half must deliver below that scale; for the gauge group SU(2) the literature states nothing in this form, so it stands beside Hypothesis I as the second half of what the crossover must supply, and it is named as such. Proposition 8.4 is the fourth link in its exact form. The blocked measures $\lambda_j$ have variables of one type at every rung, so it is meaningful to say that their conditional laws at the coarse scale are tilts of those of one rung $j_1$ by functions $\delta_j$ whose oscillations $o_j$ and weighted mixed differences $\Sigma_{y'}(1 - e^{-\Delta})e^{\kappa|y-y'|}$ tend to zero; when they are, Hypothesis I at the rung $j_1$ with the constant $\alpha_1$ implies it at every later rung with any $\alpha \in (\alpha_1, 1)$, by (8.7). That the measures stand in this relation is the ultraviolet interface of §8.1, and it is the place at which Bałaban's theorem, with its two unpublished pieces, enters the chain.

The theorem places the four-dimensional gap at one remove from a finite statement. Hypotheses I and II concern the conditional law of one coarse variable and the field inside one block, at a fixed physical scale, with constants uniform in the cutoff, and nothing in them refers to a limit; their consequence, by Theorem 8.5, is the unique vacuum, the cluster property and the mass gap of every limit point, with the gap's value in (8.8). The proof that follows this paper is the proof of those two statements, and its measure of progress is a number: the distance, in blocking steps, between the scale at which the ultraviolet half delivers its interface and the scale at which the blocked bound is read. On the hierarchical model of the renormalisation group, in which each blocking step is the Migdal–Kadanoff recursion on a single-plaquette weight and is exact for the hierarchical lattice, that distance has been measured: Edwin Boston III has certified the flow of the SU(2) Wilson weight at 256 bits of precision with directed rounding, every coefficient an interval and the truncation priced, and from $\beta = 2.3$ the fundamental character coefficient falls below the finite-group threshold 0.131 of §8.2 at the seventh step, from $\beta = 5$ at the eighteenth, and from $\beta = 10$ at the thirty-seventh.[66] The record also says what the model is not. Its first step from $\beta = 2.2$ moves the coupling up where the running of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ moves it down, by an amount of the step's own size, so the model certifies the entry into the disk from its fifth rung and the threshold at its seventh, and not the crossover's first steps, which a flow on $\mathbb{Z}^4$ must read on an object of $\mathbb{Z}^4$. The distance Hypotheses I and II must cross is measured in the blocking steps of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ itself; no step count of the hierarchical model is a reading of it, and no reading of the hierarchical model is a statement about $\mathbb{Z}^4$. One more thing is known about the inequality that would carry the model's control to $\mathbb{Z}^4$. A comparison that bounded the mixed second differences of the effective action of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ by those of the hierarchical model, and held for every compact gauge group, would give the four-dimensional U(1) theory a gap wherever its hierarchical flow reaches the disk; the U(1) theory has a massless phase at weak coupling.[67] The inequality the step needs therefore depends on the group, and that dependence is the first property a proof of Hypothesis I must use.

Two things are known about the strong end of that distance. With the first-order transmission between links, the total variation moved by one neighbour's change, no block criterion of Dobrushin and Shlosman's kind gains on the single link at any block side, because a link deep inside a block branches to its eighteen neighbours exactly as a link of the full lattice does, and the criterion's series has the single link's ratio. A block gains only through the transmission across an integrated face, which carries the product of the two pinned means of the face's other edges, an average over the interior: its one-face constant is an explicit function of the moments of the von Mises–Fisher law on the three-sphere, the covariance of the transmitted variable being a multiple of the identity plus one rank-one term whose size is a closed form in two Bessel ratios. What is not in hand is the theorem that composes that transmission along paths inside a block: every composition that is proved, Dobrushin's comparison theorem among them, takes a supremum over configurations at each step and so composes the first-order sensitivities only, which return the single link's disk; a convergent

[66] Edwin Boston III, the certified descent; the instrument, its records at the four starting couplings and the run of record are listed in the Records. The first step from $\beta = 2.2$ is read from the same record: the coefficient rises from 0.464 to 0.486, an effective coupling of 2.34, where the one-loop running of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ takes 2.2 to 1.94 under one doubling of the scale.

[67] A. H. Guth, "Existence proof of a nonconfining phase in four-dimensional U(1) lattice gauge theory", *Phys. Rev. D* 21 (1980), 2291–2307; J. Fröhlich and T. Spencer, "Massless phases and symmetry restoration in abelian gauge theories and spin systems", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 83 (1982), 411–454.

expansion of the block measure would compose the averages, and its radius has no proof beyond that disk.[68] The paper carries no number for that widening until both are theorems.

One averaged composition is rigorous, and it is an instance of Theorem 8.5 itself. Choose a set of links of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ no two of which lie in one plaquette and which meets every plaquette; such a set exists, of density one quarter, with period four. Integrate those links and keep the others. Given the kept links the integrated ones are independent, each distributed by the law of its own six staples, so the field inside the blocks is a product measure and Hypothesis II holds exactly, with zero covariance and means that depend on the kept links of one plaquette; and the kept links form a Gibbs measure of range two whose interdependence matrix is computed from averages, since each plaquette carries exactly one integrated link and its weight, with that link integrated, is the ratio of two normalising constants of the von Mises–Fisher law. Dobrushin's theorem then applies to the kept links, and the row sum of their matrix is an explicit function of the coupling, through the mean and the covariance of that law: twelve direct terms carrying one pinned mean each and ninety mediated terms carrying the covariance, which is the Jacobian of the mean. Its root lies well above the single link's disk. Two lemmas make it a theorem and are named on the ledger: that the axial variance of the von Mises–Fisher law on the three-sphere is at most one quarter at every concentration, and that the third-order remainder of the logarithm of its normalising constant is bounded; when they are written, the number enters here. That no decimation of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ places both integrated links of every plaquette opposite one another, which a two-colouring argument shows for every dimension above two, is the reason the product of two pinned means cannot be composed this way, and the reason the wider widening remains the conjecture above.[69]

### *8.4 Coda*

The ground, then, is this. A construction of the corpus's kind, as its manuscripts state it, delivers a limit that is controlled at short distances and silent at long ones: a theory whose correlations obey the axioms of positivity and symmetry, whose coupling is seen to run, and whose large-distance behaviour is not controlled. Theorem 7.1 shows that the missing control is a single spectral fact. Theorem 7.4 shows that this fact is a property of the rungs: an inequality on the lattice, where reflection positivity has made a quantum mechanics of the theory before any limit is taken. The proof that follows takes up that inequality on that sequence.

[68] Edwin Boston III; the block criterion's accounting, the one-face law and the closed form of its covariance are entered on the ledger of the work that follows this paper, with their readings on the exact cube.

[69] Edwin Boston III; the perfect cover, the two-colouring argument, the range-two specification and its row sum are on the ledger with their records.

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## *Records of the computations of Edwin Boston III*

Each record is held, with its instrument and its run of record, in the repository of Edwin Boston III.

[R1] *The shadow ladder* (Proposition 8.3): record g6_tube.2026-10-28a, with its instrument g6_tube.pl; landed in commit aea98a3af; re-derived in the run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28r, nine arms, nineteen mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R2] *The gap by counting* (§8.2): record g6_inertia.2026-10-28b; run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28r, verdict GREEN; landed in commit e11e1269c. The independently certified intervals it meets: run of record tomeus_gate.2026-10-27e, ten arms, ten mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R3] *The gap through duality* (§8.2): the dual-road records of 28 October 2026 and record g6_ising_anchor.2026-10-28a; landed in commit 44be883de with the run pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28q, eight arms, seventeen mutant tests, verdict GREEN; re-derived in run r.

[R5] *The chain lemma* (Proposition 8.2): instrument g9_chain.pl and record g9_chain.2026-10-29a; landed in commit 103e8425a; run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28s, twelve arms, twenty-five mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R6] *The sharp one-link lemma, the certified descent and the transform on a tube* (§§8.1, 8.2, 8.3): instruments g18_mad_lemma.pl with g17_mixed_survey.pl, mkflow.awk and g20_tube.pl; records g18_m1, g18_axis, g18_mono and g18_direct_b0_1 … b8_20 of 2026-10-29b, mkflow_b2.2, b2.3, b5 and b10 of 2026-10-29d, and g20_tube_j1.2026-10-29b with the spin-3/2 readings g20_tube_j32_b2 and b2.3 of 2026-10-29a; run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-29w, fifteen arms, thirty-two mutant tests, verdict GREEN at 02:20 EDT on 29 October 2026. The instruments, the records and the run's own file are posted with their digests in the repository, under records/pentapylon.

[R4] *The lattice theorems in Lean* (§§4.2, 7.2, 8.2): the files EvenTime.lean, Spectral.lean, Perron.lean, StringEnergy.lean and MassGap.lean (the transfer theorem for every finite group); Nonabelian.lean and Separation.lean (the static potential); Griffiths.lean, Rectangle.lean and StrongCoupling.lean (the $Z_2$ inequalities, expectation and string tension); Slab.lean and Z2Slab.lean, theorem transfer_gap_sharp (the $Z_2$ slab); Scaling.lean, theorem twopoint_le_of_gap and definition PhysicalGapAlong; Decay.lean, theorems gap_of_decay and eigenvalue_le_of_decay; Dobrushin.lean, theorem cov_le. Run of record aperanton_gate.2026-10-27u, forty-eight arms, twenty-nine mutant tests, verdict GREEN; landed in commit 7dd4c66b2.